ONE BLANK TEXT COMPLETIONS

1BTC Question 1

Although the committee initially regarded the proposal as overly cautious, subsequent developments suggested that such restraint was not only justified but _____.

salutary
innovative
obligatory
perfunctory
obstructive

(difficulty: 4/5)

Explanation: Although sets up a contrast with “initially …overly cautious” so we know that the proposal must turn out to be something other than that. This could be “the right amount of caution” or “not cautious enough”. The second part of the sentence, “such restraint was not only justified but also _____” shows that our target needs to describe the “restraint” as **something even better than / beyond “justified”**

Salutary means producing good effects; beneficial. Not only reasonable but actually beneficial/ a good idea. Worth keeping. *Innovative* is a positive term that fits the correct general idea of something positive, but it isn’t justified. It doesn’t pair well with “cautious” and “restraint”, and nothing in the passage indicates that it would be innovative. Not our answer. *Obligatory* means required; this is a very tempting choice. The sentiment that would be expressed by a phrase meaning “not only reasonable but required” makes sense; it is also a strong fit for the first indication that the proposal was “not overly cautious”. Keep it. *Perfunctory* (done with minimal effort) and *obstructive* (causing blockages) make no sense; in any case, these are both negative terms and we’re looking for something positive / even better than justified to contrast the negative initial sentiment.

The best two answers are *salutary* and *obligatory*. But with *obligatory,* a closer look at the definition shows why it isn’t quite correct. If it just meant “necessary” or “required *by the situation*” it could be our choice, but *obligatory* actually means something required by a legal, moral, or other rule. A closer synonym is compulsory. It doesn’t make sense to find out in the end that such restraint is required by law; it makes more sense that such restraint turned out to be a good idea / beneficial.

1BTC Question 2

The historian’s expansive account is notable less for its originality than for the _____ with which it synthesizes a wide range of previously disparate sources.

Answer choices

temerity

economy
dexterity
flamboyance
volatility

Difficulty: ⅖

Correct Answer: dexterity

Explanation: The sentence contrasts "originality" with the manner in which the historian "synthesizes a wide range of previously disparate sources". The act of successfully combining a wide, disparate range of sources into an "expansive account" requires mechanical skill and adroitness. "Dexterity" (skill in performing tasks) accurately describes

this capability. "Temerity" (excessive confidence or boldness) and "flamboyance" (the tendency to attract attention due to exuberance) describe personality traits or styles rather than the mechanical skill of synthesizing information. "Volatility" (liability to change rapidly and unpredictably) is entirely unrelated to historical research. Finally, "economy" (careful management of available resources or conciseness) contradicts the premise that the account is "expansive".

1BTC Question 3

The study is impressively documented, yet its conclusions remain _____, because the evidence it marshals is drawn from a single region and a short time span.

synoptic
circumscribed
unassailable
capacious
catalytic

(Difficulty: 3/5)

Correct Answer: circumscribed

Explanation: The conjunction "yet" signals a contrast between the study being "impressively documented" and the state of its conclusions. The clause following "because" provides the direct rationale for the blank: the evidence comes from a "single region and a short time span". This indicates a strict limitation in the study's scope. "Circumscribed" (restricted or confined within limits) precisely matches the condition of being drawn from such a narrow pool of data. "Unassailable" (unable to be attacked or questioned) contradicts the limiting nature of the evidence. "Capacious" (having a lot of space inside; roomy) and "synoptic" (taking or involving a comprehensive mental view) suggest a breadth that directly conflicts with a "single region and a short time span." "Catalytic" (causing or accelerating a change) does not relate to the geographic or temporal limits of the evidence.

1BTC Question 4

The archaeological team's discovery of intact pottery in the burial chamber was considered _____, given that previous excavations at similar sites had yielded only fragments.

fortuitous

prosaic
presumptuous
insular
contentious

Difficulty: 1/5

Correct Answer: fortuitous

Explanation: The sentence establishes a contrast between the current "discovery of intact pottery" and previous excavations that yielded "only fragments". Finding something completely intact when only broken pieces were previously found represents an unusually lucky or successful event. "Fortuitous" (happening by a lucky chance) accurately describes this fortunate discovery. "Prosaic" (commonplace or unromantic) contradicts the unique nature of finding intact pottery when others could not. "Presumptuous" (failing to observe the limits of what is permitted) applies to human

behavior, not an inanimate archaeological find. "Insular" (ignorant of or uninterested in cultures outside one's own) is unrelated to the physical state of the artifacts. "Contentious" (causing or likely to cause an argument) is unsupported, as nothing in the sentence indicates a disagreement about the discovery.

1BTC Question 5

Never one for complacency, the composer who had broken through to great success by creating _____ melodies that her audience found easy to remember and hum began working on a new symphony featuring complex atonal passages and innovative dense, interlocking polyrhythms that would challenge even the most virtuosic of musicians.

discordant
felicitous
recondite
abstruse
pedantic

Difficulty: 4/5

Correct Answer: felicitous

Explanation: The phrase "melodies that her audience found easy to remember and hum" provides the defining characteristic for the blank. Furthermore, the composer's new work features "complex atonal passages" that "challenge" musicians, which contrasts directly with her earlier, successful work. The blank requires a word that describes music that is pleasing, fitting, and highly accessible. "Felicitous" (well-chosen, pleasing, or apt) accurately describes melodies that successfully and pleasantly connect with an audience. "Discordant" (harsh or clashing in sound), "recondite" (little known or obscure), and "abstruse" (difficult to understand) all describe music that would be difficult to remember and hum, aligning perfectly with her new symphony but directly contradicting her past successes. "Pedantic" (excessively concerned with formal rules) does not logically describe the accessibility or memorability of a melody.

1BTC Question 6

The senator's long-winded speech, filled with irrelevant anecdotes and meandering digressions, proved so _____ that even her staunchest supporters began checking their phones.

trenchant
cogent
sedulous
prolix
terse

Difficulty: 3/5

Correct Answer: prolix

Explanation: The sentence describes a speech that is "long-winded" and "filled with irrelevant anecdotes and meandering digressions". The blank requires an adjective that summarizes these qualities, leading to the outcome of supporters checking their phones. "Prolix" (excessively lengthy or wordy) directly captures this meaning. "Trenchant" (incisive or vigorous) contradicts the description of the speech as rambling. "Cogent" (clear and logical) also represents the opposite of "irrelevant anecdotes and meandering digressions". "Sedulous" (diligent or persevering) describes a work ethic rather than the quality of a speech. "Terse" (brief and sparing in the use of words) directly contradicts the explicit clues "long-winded" and "meandering"

1BTC Question 7

The ancient practice of *Kigumi* is remarkably _____; it relies on a system of interlocking joints so elaborate that even a minor error in a single component's measurement will prevent the entire structure from fitting together.

Answer Choices
flexible
exacting
fragile
traditional
portable

Difficulty: 1/5

Correct Answer: exacting

Explanation: The semicolon introduces a clause that explains the blank. The system is described as "elaborate" and one where "even a minor error" prevents the structure from fitting together. This indicates a process requiring high precision. "Exacting" (making great demands on one's skill, attention, or time) precisely matches this requirement. "Flexible" contradicts the rigid requirement where a "minor error" causes failure. "Fragile" describes something easily broken, which does not align with the focus on precise measurements. "Traditional" describes the age or history of the practice, but the mechanical logic following the semicolon points to the required level of precision, not its age. "Portable" is entirely unrelated to the structural elaboration described.

1BTC Question 8

The process of extracting Tyrian purple from sea snails was famously _____; thousands of mollusks were harvested to produce only a single gram of pigment, with the vast majority of the biological material discarded.

Answer Choices
accidental

prestigious
hazardous
inefficient
durable

Difficulty: 1/5

Correct Answer: inefficient

Explanation: The clause following the semicolon provides the evidence for the blank: a massive amount of input ("thousands of mollusks") yields a tiny amount of output ("only a single gram"). This extreme ratio of input material to final product defines a process as "inefficient". "Accidental" (happening by chance) does not describe a systematic harvesting process. "Prestigious" might describe the final pigment, but the sentence explicitly focuses on the mechanics of the "extracting" process itself. "Hazardous" implies danger, which is unsupported by the text. "Durable" relates to longevity, not the ratio of raw materials to yield.

1BTC Question 9

For early Polynesian navigators, the ability to read the subtle patterns of ocean swells was _____; without this vital skill, it would have been impossible to maintain a consistent course across thousands of miles of open water.

+1

Answer Choices
advantageous
revolutionary
indispensable
ancient
difficult

Difficulty: 1/5

Correct Answer: indispensable

Explanation: The phrase "without this vital skill, it would have been impossible" establishes that the ability was absolutely necessary. "Indispensable" (absolutely necessary) perfectly matches this strict requirement. "Advantageous" (providing an advantage) and "revolutionary" (causing a dramatic change) are positive attributes, but they fall short of the absolute necessity established by "impossible to succeed without it". "Ancient" describes age and "difficult" describes the effort required, neither of which captures the essential nature of the skill required by the second clause.

1BTC Question 10

The task of documenting the dying language was _____, as the researcher had to record and transcribe thousands of hours of oral history before the community's last three native speakers passed away.

Answer Choices
controversial
urgent
celebrated
meaningful

emblematic

Difficulty: 1/5

Correct Answer: urgent

Explanation: The clause "before the community's last three native speakers passed away" establishes a strict, impending time limit. This condition necessitates a word denoting immediate action. "Urgent" aligns with this time-sensitive nature. "Meaningful" and "celebrated" are positive descriptors, but they do not specifically address the impending deadline established by the text. "Controversial" (causing public disagreement) and "emblematic" (serving as a symbol) are unsupported by the context provided in the sentence.

1BTC Question 11

The comet’s trajectory through the inner solar system proved highly _____, defying all attempts by early astronomers to accurately plot its return using standard mechanics.

Answer Choices

luminous
trivial
anomalous
harmonious
cyclical

Difficulty: 3/5

Correct Answer: anomalous

Explanation: The sentence states that the comet's path "defied all attempts" to plot it using "standard mechanics". Therefore, the trajectory must deviate from standard or expected rules. "Anomalous" (deviating from what is standard, normal, or expected) fits this requirement. "Cyclical" (occurring in cycles) contradicts the clue, as a strictly cyclical orbit would be predictable and easy to plot. "Luminous" (bright) describes appearance rather than the mechanical trajectory. "Trivial" (of little value) and "harmonious" (forming a pleasing whole) are unrelated to the predictability of the comet's path.

1BTC Question 12

While local salvage crews often operated under a self-imposed moral code of mutual aid, the formal maritime statutes of the period were often _____; the law prioritized the claims of distant investors over the rights of the sailors who risked their lives to recover the cargo.

Answer Choices
equitable
rigorous

iniquitous
precise
systematic

Difficulty: 2/5

Correct Answer: iniquitous

Explanation: The word "While" signals a contrast between the "moral code of mutual aid" and the "formal maritime statutes". The semicolon introduces an explanation of these statutes, noting they prioritized "distant investors" over the "sailors who risked their lives". This prioritization represents a lack of fairness. "Iniquitous" (grossly unfair and morally wrong) matches this description. "Equitable" (fair and impartial) is the exact opposite of the required meaning. "Rigorous" (strict or precise), "precise" (exact), and "systematic" (done according to a fixed plan) describe the execution of the law but do not capture the unfairness required to contrast with "mutual aid"

1BTC Question 13

Although early accounts of the "Green Revolution" often celebrate it as a triumph of universal cooperation, the actual distribution of new irrigation technologies was quite _____; only the wealthiest landholders possessed the capital necessary to implement the system, leaving smaller farmers in a state of relative stagnation.

Answer Choiceso
sophisticated
sporadic
exclusionary
ingenious
widespread

Difficulty: 2/5

Correct Answer: exclusionary

Explanation: The word "Although" creates a contrast between "universal cooperation" and the reality of the distribution. The clause following the semicolon explains that "only the wealthiest landholders" could participate, barring smaller farmers due to a lack of capital. "Exclusionary" accurately describes a distribution that leaves out a specific group. "Widespread" contradicts the limitation to only the wealthiest. "Sporadic" suggests an irregular distribution rather than one systematically limited by capital requirements. "Sophisticated" and "ingenious" describe the technology itself rather than the nature of its distribution.

1BTC Question 14

The use of radiocarbon dating was initially hailed as a foolproof method for establishing chronology, but recent findings suggest its results can be _____ when samples are contaminated by modern organic matter.

Answer Choices
conclusive
deceptive
infallable
transparent
banal

Difficulty: 2/5

Correct Answer: deceptive

Explanation: The conjunction "but" signals a shift from the initial view of the method as "foolproof". The condition of samples being "contaminated" indicates that the results will lead to incorrect conclusions. "Deceptive" (giving an appearance or impression different from the true one) captures this outcome. "Conclusive" and "infallable" (incapable of making mistakes) maintain the "foolproof" idea, failing to execute the required pivot. "Transparent" (easy to perceive) contradicts the misleading nature of contaminated results. "Banal" (lacking originality) does not describe the accuracy or inaccuracy of scientific data.

1BTC Question 15

Despite the high species density of the Amazonian rainforest, the soil itself is surprisingly _____; the rapid decomposition of organic matter means that nutrients are recycled into the canopy almost immediately rather than enriching the ground.

+1

Answer Choices
fertile

resilient
nutrient-poor
primeval
diverse

Difficulty: 2/5

Correct Answer: nutrient-poor

Explanation: "Despite" sets up a contrast between the "high species density" of the forest and the state of the soil. The clause following the semicolon explains that nutrients are recycled into the canopy "rather than enriching the ground". "Nutrient-poor" directly matches this description. "Fertile" (capable of producing abundant vegetation) contradicts the explicit statement that the ground is not enriched. "Resilient" (able to withstand difficult conditions), "primeval" (resembling the earliest ages), and "diverse" (showing variety) do not address the chemical composition of the soil described in the second clause.

1BTC Question 16

Though the politician's public speeches were characterized by their elegance and poise, his private letters reveal a man who was remarkably _____; he often struggled to express even the most basic sentiments without resorting to outbursts of frustration.

Answer Choices
articulate
flamboyant
ungainly
laconic
irascible

Difficulty: 2/5

Correct Answer: irascible

Explanation: The word "Though" signals a contrast between the "elegance and poise" of his public speeches and his private behavior. The semicolon introduces an explanation of this private behavior, characterized by "outbursts of frustration". "Irascible" (having a tendency to be easily angered) precisely fits this description of frustration and temper. "Articulate" aligns with his public "elegance," failing to execute the contrast required for his private life. "Flamboyant" (attracting attention due to exuberance) does not align with frustration. "Ungainly" (awkward or clumsy) typically refers to physical movement. "Laconic" (using very few words) does not capture the emotional volatility of "outbursts."

1BTC Question 17

The architect's proposal for the city's central plaza was intentionally _____; by utilizing modular, movable stages instead of permanent monuments, he aimed to create a space that could be easily reconfigured to meet the shifting needs of a diverse public.

Answer Choices
pedestrian
malleable
quotidian
monolithic
grandiose

Difficulty: 3/5

Correct Answer: malleable

Explanation: The semicolon connects the blank to an explanatory clause detailing a space that is "modular," "movable," and "easily reconfigured". This defines a design built for adaptation and change. "Malleable" (easily influenced or pliable) fits this description of structural flexibility. "Pedestrian" and "quotidian" (commonplace or ordinary) describe a lack of uniqueness rather than a capacity for reconfiguration. "Monolithic" (large, solid, and uniform) is the exact opposite of modular and movable. "Grandiose" (impressive or imposing) describes scale or style, not adaptability.

1BTC Question 18

The shaman's knowledge of medicinal flora was long dismissed as _____ by colonial botanists, who viewed his complex oral classifications as mere superstition until modern analysis revealed the presence of highly effective, previously unidentified alkaloids in his preparations.

Answer Choices
profound

baseless
esoteric
exhaustive
primitive

Difficulty: ⅗

Correct Answer: baseless

Explanation: The conjunction "until" establishes that the initial view of the botanists (the blank) contrasts with the modern discovery that the flora was "highly effective". The botanists "dismissed" the knowledge and viewed it as "mere superstition," indicating they believed it lacked factual merit. "Baseless" (without foundation in fact) accurately describes this dismissal. "Profound" and "exhaustive" are positive terms that contradict "dismissed". "Primitive" implies an early evolutionary or historical stage, but does not capture the specific idea of being factually incorrect or unscientific as required by "superstition". "Esoteric" (understood by only a few) does not equate to being dismissed as ineffective.

1BTC Question 19

The art school’s official motto—which referenced the three pillars of "purity of pigment, purity of mind, and purity of message"—was quietly subverted by the _____ use of synthetic oil paints, which professors and students alike preferred for their superior brilliance and lower cost.

Answer Choices
occasional
ubiquitous
restricted
customary
haphazard

Difficulty: 3/5

Correct Answer: ubiquitous

Explanation: The verb "subverted" indicates that the reality of the paint usage undermined the "official motto" concerning "purity of pigment". For an institutional rule to be effectively subverted by a preference shared by "professors and students alike," the contradicting behavior must be widespread. "Ubiquitous" (present, appearing, or found everywhere) provides the necessary scale to contradict the formal rule. "Occasional", "restricted", and "haphazard" describe usage that is too limited or irregular to fully subvert a school-wide motto. "Customary" is less precise than "ubiquitous" for emphasizing the overriding prevalence required to subvert a stated pillar.

1BTC Question 20

The discovery of soft tissue remnants within a fossilized dinosaur femur was initially met with intense skepticism, as the find seemed to _____ the long-held geological consensus that no organic proteins could possibly survive for millions of years.

Answer Choices
corroborate
flout
delineate
underscore
exemplify

Difficulty: 3/5

Correct Answer: flout

Explanation: The sentence outlines a "consensus that no organic proteins could possibly survive," which is confronted by the "discovery of soft tissue remnants" (organic material). This discovery directly contradicts the established consensus. "Flout" (to openly disregard a rule or convention) captures this contradiction. "Corroborate", "underscore", and "exemplify" all imply that the discovery supported or highlighted the consensus, which represents the wrong directional relationship. "Delineate" (to describe precisely) does not address the conflict between the new discovery and the old assumption.

1BTC Question 21

While the biographer's early chapters attempt to present the general's retreat as a masterclass in strategic withdrawal, this heroic narrative is _____ by the inclusion of private diaries that reveal a leader paralyzed by indecision and primarily concerned with avoiding personal accountability.

Answer Choices

accentuated
compromised
galvanized
promulgated
superseded

Difficulty: 3/5

Correct Answer: compromised

Explanation: The word "While" establishes a contrast between the "heroic narrative" of the early chapters and the reality found in the "private diaries". The diaries show the general was "paralyzed by indecision," which weakens or damages the claim of a "masterclass in strategic withdrawal". "Compromised" (having been rendered vulnerable or exposed to danger/ruin) indicates that the integrity of the heroic narrative has been damaged. "Accentuated" and "galvanized" imply

strengthening or emphasizing, which contradicts the negative revelations in the diaries. "Promulgated" means to promote or make widely known, which does not fit the relationship between the diaries and the narrative. "Superseded" implies being replaced by a newer version, whereas the narrative here is internally undermined by contradictory evidence rather than wholly replaced.

TWO BLANK TEXT COMPLETIONS

2BTC Question 1

Intense competition for dwindling sources of academic funding and recent institutional rules (i) _____the weight given to co-authored research in hiring decisions risk rendering formal collaboration (ii) _____ graduate research.

Blank (i)	**Blank (ii)**
A) constraining B) compounding C) diminishing	D) a moribund feature of E) an unscrupulous reality in F) a pervasive element in

Correct Answers:
(i) diminishing
(ii) a moribund feature of

2BTC Question 2

In a region in which geographic isolation and a longstanding culture of independence have made the use of private gasoline powered electrical generators (i) _____ , the governor elicited no great surprise when, despite pressure from an immense outside environmental lobbying organization, she (ii) _____ the proposal to tighten the relevant emissions limits.

Blank (i)	Blank (ii)

A) a marginal practice B) a norm C) an anachronism	D) ratified E) nixed F) conceded to

The fact that the empire is well known for monumental frescoes saturated with gruesome battlefield slaughter has led some with cursory knowledge of the situation to envision a ruthlessly militaristic culture; those who see method as well as content, however, may be more struck by the _____ technique required to execute their enemies, not iteratively but figuratively.

More than the administration's eager promotion of the new environmental rules, it is the fact that they had excised everyone with bona fide ecological credentials that makes it hardly expected that regulations would be greeted with such _____ by the corporate lobbyists representing the largest polluters.

Correct Answers:

(i) B) norm
(ii) E) nixed

2BTC Question 3

While the Victorian era is often associated with (i)_____ social mores, the popular literature of the time tells a different story, frequently featuring characters whose behavior was remarkably (ii)_____ and defiant of contemporary standards.

Blank (i)	Blank (ii)
progressive	predictable
staid	unconventional
eccentric	submissive

Difficulty: 3/5

Correct Answer: staid; unconventional

Explanation: The "While" signals a contrast. If the popular literature features "defiant" characters, then the era's reputation must be for being very serious and traditional (staid). The characters themselves are then the opposite of those standards (unconventional).

2BTC Question 4

The critic noted that the director's latest film was (i)_____ in its pacing, moving with a (ii)_____ that made the three-hour runtime feel significantly shorter.

Blank (i)	Blank (ii)
sluggish	lethargy
uneven	alacrity
brisk	gravitas

Difficulty: 2/5

Correct Answer: brisk; alacrity

Explanation: If a three-hour film feels "shorter," the pacing must be fast or energetic (brisk). Alacrity (brisk and cheerful readiness/speed) provides the noun form of this clue.

2BTC Question 5

In the realm of glaciology, the movement of ice sheets was long thought to be inherently (i) _____; however, recent satellite telemetry has (ii) _____ this view by showing that

subglacial water channels can cause sudden, massive surges in velocity.

Blank (i)	Blank (ii)
instantaneous	bolstered
erratic	shattered
ponderous	overlooked

Difficulty: 2/5

Correct Answer: ponderous; shattered

Explanation: The "however" indicates a pivot from a traditional view to a "sudden, massive surge." This implies the original view was that ice moved slowly or heavily (ponderous). The new evidence showing sudden movement has shattered (invalidated/destroyed) that earlier consensus.

2BTC Question 6

The ecosystem's (i) _____ is frequently underestimated; although it appears (ii) _____ after a forest fire, most of its native plant species possess deep root systems that allow them to sprout anew within weeks of the disturbance.

Blank (i)	**Blank (ii)**
vulnerability	unchanged
complexity	vibrant
hardiness	devastated

Difficulty: 1/5

Correct Answer: hardiness; devastated

Explanation: The ability to "sprout anew within weeks" of a fire defines hardiness. The "although" provides a contrast to this strength, noting that the forest looks destroyed (devastated) immediately after the fire.

2BTC Question 7

The explorer's journals were found to be (i) _____ with (ii) _____ details, providing a much more vivid picture of the interior landscape than the dry, clinical reports published by the official expedition.

Blank (i)	**Blank (ii)**
teeming	technical
sparse	evocative
devoid	mundane

Difficulty: 2/5

Correct Answer: teeming; evocative

Explanation: A "vivid picture" implies the journals were full of (teeming) details that were powerful or brought strong images to mind (evocative).

2BTC Question 8

The philosopher's (i) _____ of modern technology as a tool of social liberation has been (ii) _____ by critics who point to the increasing use of digital surveillance by authoritarian regimes.

Blank (i)	**Blank (ii)**
analysis	challenged
dismissal	supported
characterization	ignored

Difficulty: 2/5

Correct Answer: characterization; challenged

Explanation: The philosopher has a specific view or characterization of technology (liberation). The critics have evidence of the opposite (surveillance), which they use to challenge his view.

2BTC Question 9

The novelist's (i) _____ with the macabre is evident in her latest thriller, which features a (ii) _____ of gothic horror elements and modern psychological suspense.

Blank (i)	**Blank (ii)**
asphyxiation	separation

fascination	fusion
boredom	rejection

Difficulty: 2/5

Correct Answer: fascination; fusion

Explanation: If the themes are "evident" in her book, she must have a strong interest or fascination with them. Using two different styles (Gothic and Modern) in one book is a fusion (blend).

2BTC Question 10

Far from corroborating the prevailing assumption that medieval jurisprudence was inherently (i) _____, an analysis of regional manorial records reveals that local magistrates only infrequently (ii) _____ the official statutory interpretations that would have left little latitude to accommodate shifting agricultural realities.

Blank (i)	**Blank (ii)**
lenient	circumvented
dogmatic	invoked
inscrutable	repudiated

Difficulty: 5/5

Correct Answer: dogmatic; invoked

Explanation: The phrase "Far from corroborating" establishes a double-negative pivot. The second clause reveals that magistrates left themselves "latitude" (flexibility) by "infrequently" using strict rules. If they infrequently applied or called upon (invoked) these strict interpretations, then the prevailing assumption must have been the opposite: that the law was rigid and strictly rule-bound (dogmatic). "Inscrutable" (impossible to understand) is a high-level trap.

2BTC Question 11

The discovery of the Antikythera mechanism initially (i) _____ underwater archaeologists, as its bronze gears seemed far beyond the (ii) _____ mechanisms previously known to have been used in other devices manufactured during the same period.

Blank (i)	**Blank (ii)**
astounded	intricate
unimpressed	rudimentary
bewildered	ornamental

Difficulty: 2/5

Correct Answer: astounded; rudimentary

Explanation: Finding something "far beyond" what was known would naturally shock or astound the researchers. If the new mechanism is highly advanced, the previously known mechanisms from the same period must have been basic or primitive (rudimentary).

2BTC Question 12

Because the extreme pressures of deep-sea trenches render the Hadal zone (i) _____ to most forms of conventional human exploration, marine biologists mapping these chasms must rely heavily on (ii) _____ data gathered by autonomous submersibles.

Blank (i)	**Blank (ii)**
impenetrable	firsthand

inviting	indirect
incommodious	sensory

Difficulty: 2/5

Correct Answer: impenetrable; indirect

Explanation: The extreme pressures prevent "conventional human exploration," rendering the zone completely unenterable (impenetrable). "Incommodious" (uncomfortable/cramped) is a challenging trap, but it understates the lethal reality of deep-sea pressure. Because humans cannot enter, they must rely on autonomous machines, meaning the data is gathered via proxy (indirect).

2BTC Question 13

In the field of epigraphy, the (i) _____ of an undated stone inscription can often be

determined by analyzing the (ii) _____ of its lettering, as different centuries favored distinct carving techniques and stylistic flourishes.

Blank (i)	**Blank (ii)**
translation	density
significance	morphology
provenance	pigmentation

Difficulty: 4/5

Correct Answer: provenance; morphology

Explanation: The clue "different centuries" indicates a need to determine when or where the stone originated, which is its provenance. The distinct "carving techniques and stylistic flourishes" refer to the physical shape or form of the letters, known academically as morphology.

2BTC Question 14

Despite the author's (i) _____ high levels of historical accuracy, the novel is (ii) _____ small temporal errors that frustrate even the most casual readers of period fiction.

Blank (i)	**Blank (ii)**
disregard for	elevated by
avidity for	devoid of
aversion to	marred by

Difficulty: 3/5

Correct Answer: avidity for; marred by

Explanation: "Despite" sets up a contrast. If the book features errors that "frustrate" readers, the author must have had an original drive or eagerness (avidity) for accuracy. The presence of these frustrating errors means the book's quality is damaged or spoiled by them (marred by).

2BTC Question 15

The transition from nomadic to (i) _____ lifestyles in the Neolithic period was not an abrupt, monolithic event; archaeological sites show that many groups continued to seamlessly alternate between seasonal foraging and permanent farming, indicating a highly

(ii) _____ process.

Blank (i)	**Blank (ii)**
migratory	stagnant
sedentary	sequential
pastoral	fluid

Difficulty: 3/5

Correct Answer: sedentary; fluid

Explanation: The opposite of "nomadic" in an archaeological context is sedentary (settled). "Pastoral" is a trap, as pastoralists are often nomadic herders. The fact that groups "seamlessly alternated" back and forth shows the change was not a strict, one-way progression, but rather a dynamic, shifting (fluid) process.

2BTC Question 16

The diplomat's new (i) _____ approach to the crisis allowed her to secure a lasting ceasefire in a region in which dozens of previous envoys had failed entirely, drawing blanket praise for her (ii) _____, even from those who still had serious concerns about the acumen of her recent gambit.

Blank (i)	**Blank (ii)**
judicious	sagacity
brazen	partiality
circumspect	efficacy

Difficulty: 4/5

Correct Answer: brazen; efficacy

Explanation: The sentence sets up a contrast between the results of the diplomat's actions and the wisdom of her methods. Because her action is described as a "gambit" (a risky, calculated move), her approach is best described as bold or brazen. Since she succeeded where dozens failed, she drew praise for her effectiveness, or efficacy. She receives this praise *even from* people who still doubt her "acumen" (wisdom/shrewdness), meaning they can't praise her "sagacity" (wisdom), but they have to admit her risky methods got the job done.

2BTC Question 17

Even the city's (i) _____ infrastructure, which had been widely praised as a marvel of modern engineering just a decade ago, was completely unequipped to handle the (ii) _____ growth of the population, leading to frequent blackouts and water shortages.

Blank (i)	**Blank (ii)**

antiquated	unprecedented
formidable	gradual
dilapidated	anticipated

Difficulty: 3/5

Correct Answer: formidable; unprecedented

Explanation: The phrase "Even the..." followed by "praised as a marvel" requires the first blank to describe something highly capable or impressive (formidable). If even a formidable system failed, the population growth must have been massive or larger than anything seen before (unprecedented), as merely "gradual" growth would likely have been accommodated.

THREE BLANK TEXT COMPLETIONS

3BTC Question 1 (3 blanks) — Difficulty: 4/5

The report adopts (i) _____ tone, but the framing of its key recommendation is so (ii) _____ that critics have justifiably panned the document as (iii) _____ rather than resolute.

(i)	(ii)	(iii)
an authoritative	fuzzy	equivocal
A conciliatory	peremptory	forthrite
a tentative	indelicate	definitive

Correct Answers:
(i) authoritative
(ii) fuzzy
(iii) equivocal

Explanation:
The logic hinges on *surface clarity masking real ambiguity*. **authoritative** describes tone; **Fuzzy** explains the obscurity and lack of a clear stance; **equivocal** captures critics' response. **Conciliatory** is tempting but doesn't explain ambiguity.

3BTC Question 2 (3 blanks)

Though the poet adopted the restrictive formal requirements of the sestina expressly in the interest of making his poem appear (i) _____, the result fell somewhat short of this goal: even those few readers who did find the shape pleasing still agreed that that the appearance was (ii) _____ and that upon reflection, the logic underpinning it was (iii) _____.

Answer choices

(i)	(ii)	(iii)
farcical loquatious eloquent	misleading exemplary manifest	stringent tenable fallacious

— Difficulty: 3/5

Correct Answers:
(i) eloquent
(ii) misleading
(iii) fallacious

3BTC Question 3 (Art Restoration)

Far from being a straightforward application of solvents, the restoration of Renaissance frescoes is often a highly (i) _____ endeavor; the restorer must carefully contend with the chemical (ii) _____ of centuries-old pigments, which, if treated with modern cleaning agents, can undergo a complete (iii) _____ rather than returning to their original brilliance.

Blank (i)	**Blank (ii)**	**Blank (iii)**
elementary	homogeneity	purification
formulaic	durability	preservation

treacherous	idiosyncrasies	transmutation

Difficulty: 3/5

Correct Answer: treacherous; idiosyncrasies; transmutation

Explanation: The phrase "Far from being a straightforward application" signals that the process is dangerous, difficult, or unpredictable (treacherous). "Formulaic" is a trap for readers who miss the pivot. Because the pigments react poorly to modern chemicals, they do not possess uniformity (homogeneity) but rather unique, unpredictable traits (idiosyncrasies). The result of using the wrong chemical is a negative change in the pigment's fundamental nature (transmutation), directly contrasting the intended "original brilliance."

3BTC Question 4 (Epidemiology)

Epidemiological models were widely praised as a practical and elegant (i) _____ in the face of pandemics until one was confronted with an active outbreak scenario. Its architects had treated human contact networks as (ii) _____, imagining a level of societal (iii) _____ that was fundamentally incompatible with the realities of urban mobility, and rendering the models themselves nugatory.

Blank (i)	**Blank (ii)**	**Blank (iii)**
lodestar	deterministic	regimentation
liability	amorphous	fluidity
anachronism	erratic	anarchy

Difficulty: 5/5

Correct Answer: lodestar; deterministic; regimentation

Explanation: To establish the overarching logic, the end of the sentence states the models were rendered "nugatory" (useless) because urban mobility clashed with what the architects imagined. If mobility (fluidity/movement) ruined the models, the architects must have imagined order or strict control (regimentation) and treated networks as highly predictable and rule-bound (deterministic). Prior to this failure, the models were praised as a guiding light or perfect standard (lodestar) for handling pandemics.

3BTC Question 5 (Linguistics & Translation)

Translating the poetry of the ancient epoch is rarely a matter of finding direct linguistic equivalents; because the original language relies on a highly (i) _____ syntax that modern tongues cannot seamlessly replicate, translators are often forced to choose between maintaining the literal meaning and capturing the verse's aural (ii) _____, a painful compromise that almost inevitably leaves purists feeling (iii) _____.

Blank (i)	**Blank (ii)**	**Blank (iii)**

lucid	logic	aggrieved
streamlined	monotony	euphoric
labyrinthine	resonance	vindicated

Difficulty: 2/5

Correct Answer: labyrinthine; resonance; aggrieved

Explanation: If modern tongues cannot replicate the syntax because it is too complex, it is twisting or maze-like (labyrinthine). Translators must choose between literal meaning and the poem's musical sound or flow (resonance). Because this is a "painful compromise" where something is always lost, purists of the original text will feel resentful or wronged (aggrieved).

3BTC Question 6 (Accountability & Politics)

The committee’s decision to publish the heavily redacted report was framed as an act of unprecedented transparency, yet dissenting watchdogs argued the gesture was

fundamentally (i) _____; by intentionally excising the most specific testimonies, the document provided only an illusion of disclosure, a tactic that ultimately served to (ii) _____ the very systemic abuses it was purportedly commissioned to (iii) _____.

Blank (i)	**Blank (ii)**	**Blank (iii)**
magnanimous	sensationalize	shroud
categorical	insulate	codify
disingenuous	dismantle	extirpate

Difficulty: 4/5 Correct Answer: disingenuous; insulate; extirpate Explanation: If the report provided "only an illusion of disclosure," the claim of transparency was not just false, but deliberately misleading or insincere (disingenuous). By hiding the most specific testimonies, the report actually protected or shielded (insulated) the abuses. This creates a dark irony, as the committee's original, purported goal was to root out or destroy (extirpate) those very abuses. "Shroud" is a trap for blank three, as the committee wouldn't be purportedly commissioned to hide things.

3BTC Question 7 (Astrophysics)

For decades, the existence of a specific theoretical particle was considered an indisputable cornerstone of galactic mechanics, yet recent aberrant readings from the deep-space probe have rendered the previously settled discourse remarkably (i) _____; if these findings are verified by independent observatories, astrophysicists may be compelled to (ii) _____ theoretical frameworks that have long been treated as entirely (iii) _____.

Blank (i)	**Blank (ii)**	**Blank (iii)**
torpid	scrap	erroneous
harmonious	simulate	speculative
contentious	underwrite	sacrosanct

Difficulty: 3/5

Correct Answer: contentious; scrap; sacrosanct

Explanation: "Aberrant readings" that challenge an "indisputable cornerstone" would cause arguments and make the discourse highly debated (contentious). If the new, contradictory findings are true, scientists will have to abandon or throw away (scrap) the old models. These old models were previously treated as sacred or never to be challenged (sacrosanct).

3BTC Question 8 (Agriculture & Botany)

The corporate assertion that the new genetically modified cultivar would completely eradicate the need for commercial pesticides was quickly revealed to be mere (i) _____; while the crop effectively repelled certain native beetles, it exhibited a surprising level of (ii) _____ when exposed to an invasive species of aphid, necessitating a level of chemical intervention that thoroughly (iii) _____ the developers' initial promises.

Blank (i)	**Blank (ii)**	**Blank (iii)**
humility	immunity	corroborated
bluster	debilitation	exceeded
foresight	adaptation	subverted

Difficulty: 3/5

Correct Answer: bluster; debilitation; subverted

Explanation: The claim that they would "completely eradicate" pesticides was false, making it empty, boastful talk (bluster). The crop resisted beetles but fell victim to aphids, meaning it exhibited a weakness or impairment (debilitation). Because the farmers still had to use chemicals, the reality contradicted or undermined (subverted) the initial corporate claims.

3BTC Question 9 (History of Technology)

Early nineteenth-century scholars often called the nascent telegraph system an absolute (i) _____ that would increasingly overwhelm citizens with the sheer volume of frivolity it would spread; ironically, contemporary scholars recognize the wire network as a uniquely (ii) _____ force that ultimately helped to (iii) _____ the administrative chaos created by the rapidly expanding railroad empire.

Blank (i)	**Blank (ii)**	**Blank (iii)**
marvel	chaotic	disguise
bane	cohesive	compound
boon	malignant	bridle

Difficulty: 3/5

Correct Answer: bane; cohesive; bridle

Explanation: Critics viewed the telegraph negatively, as a source of distress or annoyance (bane). "Marvel" and "boon" are traps for those who miss the negative clue ("overwhelm...

frivolity") and assume the first blank matches the positive second half. The "ironically" sets up a pivot: modern scholars view it positively. Specifically, it helped manage the "administrative chaos" of the railroads, meaning it was a unifying or connecting force (cohesive). By organizing the railroads, it helped to rein in or control (bridle) the chaos.

3BTC Question 10 (Literary Biographies)

The recently deceased author's newly available private journals depict a writer of insurmountable (i) _____; though widely published letters to her editor are filled with confessions of (ii) _____, the journals (iii) _____ the popular belief that even behind closed doors, she was far from the impervious figure she carefully portrayed to the public.

Blank (i)	**Blank (ii)**	**Blank (iii)**
incertitude	vainglory	buttress
conviction	inadequacy	repudiate
equanimity	contrition	dispel

Difficulty: 5/5

Correct Answer: incertitude; vainglory; buttress

Explanation: This question forces a holistic reading of the public-versus-private contrasts. The prompt states she "carefully portrayed" an "impervious figure" (untouchable/arrogant) to the public. Her letters to the editor match this persona, containing confessions of extreme pride or arrogance (vainglory). Her private journals, however, show the opposite: a writer plagued by self-doubt (incertitude). Because her private journals reveal this deep insecurity, they actively confirm or support (buttress) the belief that her impervious public persona was a facade, and that she was not truly untouchable behind closed doors.

3BTC Question 11

When classical economists produce mathematical forecasts of market behavior that prove to be somewhat (i) _____, outside analysts tend to credit the fallacy of the underlying premise that consumers are highly (ii) _____ actors; statistical analysis, however, demonstrates that these models are most likely to break down due to a failure to account for externalities and that rational self-interest, as the economists understand it, is surprisingly compatible with seemingly (iii) _____ psychological impulses.

Blank (i)	**Blank (ii)**	**Blank (iii)**
errant	altruistic	methodical
prescient	dispassionate	irrational
unimpeachable	capricious	ingrained

Difficulty: 5/5

Correct Answer: errant; dispassionate; irrational

Explanation: This question utilizes a sophisticated Anti-Real-World trap layered over a Double Pivot. The sentence begins by noting that the analysts are attempting to figure out why the forecasts "break down," meaning the mathematical models are initially shown to be flawed, off-course, or (errant). The distractors "prescient" and "unimpeachable" are direct opposites, designed to trap readers who fail to connect the opening clause to the later phrase "break down."

When these forecasts fail, outside analysts blame the classic economic premise that humans are unemotional, calculating, or (dispassionate). The pivot ("however") completely subverts this expectation. Anyone familiar with basic economics expects the passage to agree that human irrationality breaks the models. Instead, the sentence reveals that the models actually fail because of "externalities," not because the original premise about human behavior was wrong.

In fact, the economists' premise of "rational self-interest" actually works perfectly well alongside psychological impulses that only appear to be illogical or (irrational). This requires Threading the Needle: the test-taker must reconcile "rational self-interest" with impulses that are "compatible" but "seemingly" the opposite. The distractors "capricious" (for blank ii) and "methodical" (for blank iii) serve as severe Displaced Target traps. If a test-taker misses the "seemingly" or misreads the pivot, they will place the unpredictable/irrational word in the second blank and the rational word in the third.

3BTC Question 12

The advent of the electrical spotlight rendered the (i) _____ acting styles of the gaslight era (ii) _____; suddenly bathed in brilliant illumination, performers found that the grand

gestures once required to reach the back rows had to be abandoned in favor of a far more (iii) _____ approach.

Blank (i)	**Blank (ii)**	**Blank (iii)**
restrained	compelling	didactic
melodramatic	verisimilar	subtle
esoteric	gauche	lethargic

Difficulty: 4/5

Correct Answer: melodramatic; gauche; subtle

Explanation: The "grand gestures" of the past describe a style that was overly showy or exaggerated (melodramatic). Once the stage was brightly lit, these massive gestures looked cheap, tasteless, or tactless (gauche). Consequently, the actors had to abandon this style for one that was quieter, smaller, and more delicate (subtle).

3BTC Question 13

The encryption algorithm's (i) _____ mathematical architecture was ultimately undermined by the administrators' (ii) _____; their failure to update basic protocols transformed a theoretically secure network into one that was embarrassingly (iii) _____.

Blank (i)	**Blank (ii)**	**Blank (iii)**
byzantine	dereliction	redundant
rudimentary	hubris	porous
inviolable	pedantry	superfluous

Difficulty: 4/5

Correct Answer: inviolable; dereliction; porous

Explanation: The "failure to update basic protocols" points to a severe neglect of duty (dereliction) by the administrators. This failure "undermined" a system that was theoretically perfectly secure or unbreakable (inviolable). Because it was undermined by neglect, the

network became easily breached or full of holes (porous).

3BTC Question 14

Although comparisons between the newly discovered transitional fossil and an older predecessor were taken as (i) _____ the long-held theory of slow, incremental avian evolution when the preliminary topological analysis showed them to be (ii) _____, more rigorous spectrographic analysis has ultimately shown its internal bone structures to be so far from (iii) _____ its slightly older predecessor that it must be the result of accelerated adaptation.

Blank (i)	**Blank (ii)**	**Blank (iii)**
confounding	anomalous	pathologizing
upending	disparate	incompatible with
buttressing	isomorphic	conforming with

Difficulty: 5/5

Correct Answer: buttressing; isomorphic; conforming with

Explanation: This question relies on a complex chronological double-pivot. Externally, the preliminary topological analysis made the fossils appear identical or of the same shape (isomorphic). Because they appeared the same despite being of different ages, scientists initially believed this supported or strengthened (buttressing) the theory that evolution happens very slowly.

The distractors "upending" and "disparate" function as classic Displaced Target traps. They are highly tempting because they perfectly describe the ultimate truth of the fossils (they are radically different and destroy the old theory); however, placing them in the first two blanks violates the chronological syntax of what was initially believed based on the preliminary analysis.

The second pivot arrives with the spectrographic analysis, revealing a hidden internal reality: their structures are actually radically different. Blank (iii) relies on a Double Negative

Pivot structure. The phrase "so far from" requires a word that means "similar to" in order to create the ultimate meaning of being very different. If its internal structure is "so far from" matching or aligning (conforming with) the older fossil, then rapid internal change occurred. The distractor "incompatible with" preys on test-takers who understand that the fossils are different but fail to account for the negating syntax of "so far from." Finally, "pathologizing" acts as an Out of Scope vocabulary trap, offering a sophisticated word related to diagnosing disease that has no logical place in an evolutionary and morphological context.

very fast or sped-up (accelerated) rate of adaptation. Because the change was fast, it is "far from" the old theory, which must have assumed that change was slow, gradual, or step-by-step (incremental). By disproving the slow theory, the new fossil completely overturned or flipped (upended) the traditional timeline.

3BTC Question 15

Expecting an atmosphere of unbroken (i) _____, modern readers are often startled by the (ii) _____ laced throughout the ancient philosopher's treatises; yet her frequent use of satirical humor was not merely intended to entertain but rather to serve as a (iii) _____ the logical fallacies of her contemporaries.

Blank (i)	**Blank (ii)**	**Blank (iii)**
dogmatism	pedantry	shallow diversion from
orthodoxy	fluidity	pompous counterpoint to
solemnity	levity	shrewd debunking of

Difficulty: 5/5

Correct Answer: solemnity; levity; shrewd debunking of

Explanation: Blank i appears before any strong evidence for what it will contain, but is followed by the information that modern readers, expecting whatever was in blank i, will be startled by the contents of blank ii. At this point, any pair of contrasting terms could work. For instance, dogmatism (rigid adherence to a set of beliefs) could be startlingly contrasted by fluidity (the ability to flow, change, or adapt easily).

But the real clue comes from the next phrase in which "satirical humor" is referenced. Although this comes after the word yet, the contrast is not set up as "she uses [blank ii] and yet she also uses satirical humor". Instead, the phrasing shows that the humor is the very thing laced throughout the text. At this point, the only option for blank ii is levity (humor or frivolity), since neither pedantry (excessive concern with minor details or rules) nor fluidity fit. With levity in ii, blank i must be an expectation that would make levity startling; dogmatism and orthodoxy (a set of generally accepted beliefs) fit the real-world stereotypes of an ancient philosopher but are both conceptually compatible with levity, so only solemnity (seriousness and dignity) works.

The most difficult part of this may be Blank (iii). There is a tricky final pivot that is difficult to follow, and it is reasonable to imagine that the humor is simply a fun change of pace, making "shallow diversion from" (a minor or superficial distraction) tempting. But the phrase "not merely intended to entertain but rather..." requires threading the needle: the humor has a strict purpose beyond diversion. A pompous (affectedly and irritatingly self-important) counterpoint (an argument or theme used to create a contrast) implies two things that are not justified in the text: there is no indication

that the philosopher is pompous, nor is it implied that her humor is directly contrasted with a lack of humor in her contemporaries. The only option left, that it is a shrewd (astute, sharp) debunking (expose of a falsehood), lands these expectations by providing a mechanism to expose the fallacies.

3BTC Question 16

The executives' carefully crafted narrative of fiscal stability was (i) _____ by the leaked documents; despite the board's concerted efforts to (ii) _____ the quarter's staggering financial hemorrhage, their strategy of dissimulation proved (iii) _____ once the aggressive whistleblowing began.

Blank (i)	**Blank (ii)**	**Blank (iii)**
vindicated	mitigate	triumphant
demolished	broadcast	futile
preempted	camouflage	serendipitous

Difficulty: 4/5

Correct Answer: demolished; camouflage; futile

Explanation: The board employed a "strategy of dissimulation," meaning their goal was to hide or disguise (camouflage) the financial losses. Because of the "aggressive whistleblowing," this attempt to hide the truth failed and was completely useless (futile). Therefore, their fake narrative of stability was completely destroyed or ruined (demolished) by the leaks.

3BTC Question 17

While the physician's early treatises on epidemiology were considered (i) _____ by her contemporaries, who steadfastly defended the established humoral theories, modern medical historians view these same texts as remarkably (ii) _____; her strict insistence on empirical observation, though widely (iii) _____ during her own era, ultimately laid the groundwork for contemporary contagion models.

Blank (i)	**Blank (ii)**	**Blank (iii)**
aberrant	visionary	spurned
hackneyed	antiquated	venerated
sacrosanct	tortuous	verified

Difficulty: 2/5

Correct Answer: aberrant; visionary; spurned

Explanation: The word "While" establishes a contrast between how the physician’s treatises were viewed by her "contemporaries" and how they are viewed by "modern medical historians." The first clause notes that her peers "steadfastly defended the established humoral theories," indicating they would have viewed her new ideas as a severe deviation from the accepted norm. "Aberrant" (departing from an accepted standard) captures this deviation. "Hackneyed" (unoriginal and trite) and "sacrosanct" (regarded as too important to be interfered with) contradict the premise of her introducing an actively rejected new theory.

The second clause contrasts this past rejection with the modern view. Because her work "ultimately laid the groundwork for contemporary contagion models," modern historians must view it as ahead of its time. "Visionary" (thinking about or planning the future with imagination or wisdom) accurately describes this foresight. "Antiquated" (old-fashioned or outdated) and "tortuous" (full of twists and turns) fail to capture the positive modern assessment of her foundational work.

The semicolon introduces a final clause that expands on her historical treatment. The word "though" signals a contrast between her ultimate success ("laid the groundwork") and her

treatment "during her own era." Therefore, her insistence on empirical observation must have been ignored or rejected at the time. "Spurned" (rejected with disdain or contempt) fits this context perfectly. "Venerated" (regarded with great respect) represents the opposite of her historical treatment. "Verified" (demonstrated to be true) describes what ultimately happened to her theories later, but placing this word in the third blank violates the chronological constraint of how she was treated "during her own era."

3BTC Question 18

Ostensibly initiated to (i) _____ the perceived blight of densely packed, mixed-use neighborhoods by replacing them with streamlined arterial highways, the mid-century urban renewal project ultimately proved to be entirely (ii) _____; the demolition of these vibrant, organic community networks created isolated zones of severe economic stagnation, an outcome far more (iii) _____ than the minor logistical inefficiencies the planners had originally sought to cure.

Blank (i)	**Blank (ii)**	**Blank (iii)**
alleviate	ruinous	pernicious
compound	providential	fleeting
legitimize	nominal	incidental

Difficulty: 3/5

Correct Answer: alleviate; ruinous; pernicious

Explanation: The sentence begins with the adverb "Ostensibly" (apparently or purportedly, but perhaps not actually), which establishes that the planners' original goal will contrast with the actual outcome of the project. The first clause states they sought to address "perceived blight" by replacing neighborhoods with highways. To address or fix a perceived urban problem requires a word denoting improvement or relief. "Alleviate" (to make a problem less severe) fits this intended goal. "Compound" (to make something worse) contradicts the logical goal of an urban renewal project, and "legitimize" (to make lawful or valid) does not logically apply to the concept of blight.

The second clause states that the project "ultimately proved to be" something that contrasts with the initial goal. The text following the semicolon provides the evidence: the project "created isolated zones of severe economic stagnation." Because the result was active destruction of the community's economic health, the project was a failure. "Ruinous" (disastrous or destructive) accurately categorizes this outcome. "Providential" (occurring at a favorable time; opportune) represents the opposite outcome, while "nominal" (existing in name only, or very small) vastly understates the "severe" impact described.

The final blank compares this new "stagnation" to the "minor logistical inefficiencies" the planners originally tried to cure. The text establishes that this new outcome is "severe" and

caused by the "demolition" of vibrant networks. "Pernicious" (having a harmful effect, especially in a gradual or subtle way) accurately captures this deep, damaging outcome. "Fleeting" (lasting for a very short time) and "incidental" (happening as a minor accompaniment to something else) both incorrectly minimize the severity of the newly created economic stagnation.

3BTC Question 19

For decades, forest ecologists viewed trees as strictly (i) _____ entities, battling one another for sunlight and soil nutrients; however, the discovery of vast underground mycorrhizal networks has revealed a highly (ii) _____ system in which stronger trees actually pump resources to weaker saplings, a finding that has largely (iii) _____ the traditional, purely competitive model of forest dynamics.

Blank (i)	**Blank (ii)**	**Blank (iii)**
autonomous	interdependent	invalidated
magnanimous	stratified	fortified
vulnerable	volatile	anticipated

Difficulty: 2/5

Correct Answer: autonomous; interdependent; invalidated

Explanation: The first clause describes trees "battling one another" for resources. The phrase "strictly (i) _____ entities" implies they were previously thought to operate as separate, self-contained units. "Autonomous" (having the freedom to act independently) fits this view of individual competition. "Magnanimous" (generous or forgiving) and "vulnerable" (susceptible to physical or emotional attack or harm) do not align with the description of fierce competition for survival.

The pivot word "however" introduces a contrast. The discovery shows that trees "pump resources to weaker saplings." This describes a connected, mutually reliant relationship. "Interdependent" (dependent on each other) precisely captures this dynamic. "Stratified" (arranged in layers or classes) and "volatile" (liable to change rapidly and unpredictably) do not describe a system of mutual resource sharing.

The final clause describes the effect of this new finding on the "traditional, purely competitive model." Because the new evidence shows cooperation rather than strict competition, it proves the old model wrong. "Invalidated" (proved to be false or unsound) fits this outcome perfectly. "Fortified" (strengthened) represents the opposite outcome, and "anticipated" (expected or predicted) does not fit, as the traditional model did not predict its own contradiction.

3BTC Question 20

Although the founders of the Arts and Crafts movement ostensibly sought to (i) _____ the working class by championing the dignity of manual labor over industrial mechanization, their bespoke goods were ultimately so expensive that they became entirely (ii) _____ to the very laborers they meant to uplift; consequently, the movement functioned more as a luxury aesthetic for the wealthy than a (iii) _____ social reform.

Blank (i)	**Blank (ii)**	**Blank (iii)**
emancipate	unattainable	substantive
pacify	indispensable	specious
subjugate	repugnant	illusory

Difficulty: 2/5

Correct Answer: emancipate; unattainable; substantive

Explanation: The word "Although" establishes a contrast between the movement's original intent and its ultimate function. The first clause states the founders sought to do something positive for the working class by "championing the dignity of manual labor" and attempting to "uplift" them. "Emancipate" (to free from restriction or control) aligns with this goal of empowerment and uplift. "Pacify" (to quell the anger or agitation of) suggests a desire to control rather than uplift, and "subjugate" (to bring under domination) is the exact opposite of the movement's stated goals.

The second clause reveals the reality of their efforts: the goods were "so expensive" that they had a negative relationship with the laborers. "Unattainable" (not able to be reached or achieved) accurately describes goods that are too expensive for a specific group to purchase. "Indispensable" (absolutely necessary) contradicts the fact that the laborers could not afford them, and "repugnant" (extremely distasteful) describes a feeling of disgust rather than a financial barrier.

The final clause concludes that because only the wealthy could afford the goods, the movement failed as a social reform. The blank requires an adjective describing a reform that is real, meaningful, or highly effective, which the movement failed to be. "Substantive" (having a firm basis in reality and therefore important or meaningful) accurately describes the kind of reform the movement failed to achieve. "Specious" (superficially plausible, but actually wrong) and "illusory" (based on illusion; not real) describe exactly what the movement was, which violates the syntax of functioning "more as a luxury aesthetic... than a [blank] social reform."

3BTC Question 21

Although traditional portrait painters initially dismissed early photography as a strictly (i) _____ process devoid of human soul, pioneering photographers quickly proved the camera to be a remarkably (ii) _____ instrument; by manipulating light and shadow, they created images that were as emotionally (iii) _____ as the finest academic paintings.

Blank (i)	**Blank (ii)**	**Blank (iii)**
mechanistic	expressive	evocative
subversive	uncompromising	vapid
whimsical	obsolete	extraneous

Difficulty: 2/5

Correct Answer: mechanistic; expressive; evocative

Explanation: The word "Although" establishes a contrast between the initial view of "traditional portrait painters" and what "pioneering photographers" later proved. The first clause describes photography as a process "devoid of human soul," meaning it was viewed as a cold, automatic, or purely physical recording of reality. "Mechanistic" (determined by physical processes alone) fits this view perfectly. "Subversive" (seeking to disrupt an established system) and "whimsical" (playfully quaint or fanciful) do not align with the concept of lacking a human soul or artistic spirit.

The second clause counters this initial view. If photographers proved the camera could create art with "human soul," the instrument must be capable of conveying emotion or meaning. "Expressive" (effectively conveying thought or feeling) captures this capability. "Uncompromising" (showing an unwillingness to make concessions) and "obsolete" (no longer produced or used) do not logically follow the demonstration of artistic capability.

The final clause provides the evidence for the camera's capability: by manipulating light and shadow, they created images comparable to "the finest academic paintings." The blank requires a word that positively describes the emotional resonance of these paintings. "Evocative" (bringing strong images, memories, or feelings to mind) fits this requirement perfectly. "Vapid" (offering nothing that is stimulating or challenging) is the exact opposite of the required meaning. "Extraneous" (irrelevant or unrelated to the subject) does not describe the emotional quality of a work of art.

SENTENCE EQUIVALENCE

SE Question 1

Select the two answer choices that, when used to complete the sentence, fit the meaning of the sentence as a whole and produce completed sentences that are alike in meaning.

(1) The theory, long seen as _____ by all but a handful of academics, was given new life by recent findings demonstrating several practical applications.

- ☐ premature
- ☐ implausible
- ☐ superficial
- ☐ prescient
- ☐ percipient
- ☐ dubious

(difficulty: 3/5)

Explanation: Starting from the sentence, we know that the theory was given new life when recent findings showed practical applications. This demonstrates that it 1) needed new life and 2) demonstrating several practical applications created that new life. Put together, it seems that the theory was not in favor because it was viewed as lacking practical applications. Since our blank is how it was viewed by “all but a handful of academics”, it makes sense that most people would see it that way. Our target should be a negative term and describe a theory that is “out of favor” or “unlikely to have practical applications”.

Starting from the answer choices, *premature* means too early and lacks a partner; *prescient* (having awareness and knowledge of the future) is somewhat related but positive rather than negative. Neither fits our evidence. *Percipient* (having a good understanding or perspective) is adequately similar to *prescient* to serve as a partner, but as noted above, neither fits our target. *Implausible* means “too far fetched to be real” and could work. *Superficial* means “surface level only” and though negative, nothing shows up that this theory was deep/ not shallow. *Dubious* (not to be relied upon, suspect) is a good fit for both elements of our target; it also allows the sentence to have an adequately equivalent definition to that offered by *implausible.*

Correct Answer: implausible and dubious

SE Question 2

Although initially praised as visionary, the project was ultimately judged _____, largely because its scope far exceeded that justified the available evidence.

☐ untenable
☐ impractical
☐ visionary
☐ coherent
☐ incendiary
☐ orthodox

— Difficulty: 1/5

Correct Answers: untenable; impractical

SE Question 3

The author’s prose was never criticized for lacking _____, even by critics who found the fundamental thesis untenable.

☐ limpidity
☐ pellucidity
☐ ambition
☐ focus
☐ accessibility
☐ obfuscation

— Difficulty: 4/5

Correct Answers: limpidity; pellucidity

SE Question 4

What first appeared to be a _____ measure was later revealed to have significant staying power beyond its initial projected tenure.

☐ transformative
☐ evanescent
☐ sweeping
☐ unremarkable
☐ ephemeral
☐ comprehensive

— Difficulty: 4/5

Correct Answers: ephemeral and evanescent

SE Question 5

The senator's sudden reversal on the controversial tax initiative was widely criticized as _____, driven entirely by the impending midterm elections rather than by any genuine ideological evolution.

☐ steadfast
☐ impulsive
☐ opportunistic
☐ quixotic
☐ mercenary
☐ altruistic

Difficulty: 4/5

Correct Answers: opportunistic; mercenary

Explanation: The clue "driven entirely by the impending midterm elections rather than by any genuine ideological evolution" indicates that the senator changed his mind simply to gain an immediate political advantage. "Opportunistic" describes taking advantage of circumstances for personal gain. "Mercenary" (primarily concerned with making money or gaining advantage at the expense of ethics) creates an equivalent sentence criticizing the senator's self-serving motives.

— Difficulty: 4/5

Correct Answers: esoteric and arcane

SE Question 6

The researcher’s conclusions were criticized not for being incorrect, but for being _____ and for relying too heavily on a narrow set of assumptions.

- ☐ reductive
- ☐ abrasive
- ☐ meticulous
- ☐ comprehensive
- ☐ nuanced
- ☐ simplistic

— Difficulty: 1/5

Correct Answers: reductive; simplistic

SE Question 7

The music critic argued that the new band's overnight breakthrough success was not artifice created through bribes or industry meddling but rather resulted from _____ consensus formed after influential reviewers attended a recent performance.

☐ manufactured
☐ spontaneous
☐ tacit
☐ durable
☐ contrived
☐ organic

— Difficulty: 2/5

Correct Answers: tacit, organic

SE Question 8

Both sides recognized that the policy's central compromise was _____, but those who ultimately voted against it refused to accept this as sufficient justification for what they considered an abdication of principle.

- ☐ principled
- ☐ scrupulous
- ☐ expedient
- ☐ inflexible
- ☐ pragmatic
- ☐ doctrinaire

— Difficulty: 5/5

Correct Answers: pragmatic; expedient

SE Question 9

Designed to avoid interfering with the animals' natural behaviors, the new radio transmitters were remarkably _____, allowing the monitored falcons to hunt and navigate without any physical hindrance.

☐ unrestrictive

☐ conspicuous

☐ unencumbering

☐ resilient

☐ cumbersome

☐ rigid

Difficulty: 1/5

Correct Answer: unrestrictive, unencumbering Explanation: The phrase "allowing the monitored falcons to hunt and navigate without any physical hindrance" provides a direct definition for the blank. The sentence requires a word that means free from restriction or physical burden. "Unrestrictive" (not placing limits or restrictions on someone or something) and "unencumbering" (not acting as a burden or impediment) perfectly match this requirement. "Cumbersome" (large or heavy and therefore difficult to carry or use) and "rigid" (unable to bend or be forced out of shape) represent the exact opposite of the desired meaning. "Resilient" (able to withstand or recover quickly from difficult conditions) is a positive trait but does not relate to physical hindrance. "Conspicuous" (standing out so as to be clearly visible) relates to visibility rather than physical movement.

SE Question 10

While the physicist’s theoretical model of the plasma's behavior was beautifully symmetrical, the actual data collected from the reactor proved to be far more _____, refusing to conform to such neat mathematical boundaries.

☐ chaotic ☐ proportionate ☐ turbulent ☐ deterministic ☐ tractable ☐ uniform

Difficulty: 2/5 Correct Answer: chaotic, turbulent Explanation: The word "While" establishes a contrast between the theoretical model, described as "beautifully symmetrical" and having "neat mathematical boundaries," and the "actual data collected." Therefore, the data must exhibit a lack of symmetry or predictable boundaries. "Chaotic" (in a state of complete confusion and disorder) and "turbulent" (characterized by conflict, disorder, or confusion; not controlled or calm) both accurately describe a system that refuses to conform to neat models. "Proportionate" (corresponding in size or amount to something else) and "uniform" (remaining the same in all cases and at all times) are synonyms for the theoretical model, failing to execute the contrast. "Deterministic" (relating to the philosophical doctrine that all events are determined completely by previously existing causes) implies a rigid predictability that contradicts the refusal to conform. "Tractable" (easy to control or influence) does not describe unpredictable physical data.

SE Question 11

Sociological metrics reveal that declining participation in the electorate is often partnered with the accretion of other signs of highly _____ citizenship; thus, while pundits typically decry the waning exercise of suffrage as evidence of deepening civic apathy, it is more likely that alternative factors are driving the abstention.

☐ engaged ☐ docile ☐ invested ☐ cynical ☐ apathetic ☐ scrupulous

Difficulty: 4/5 Correct Answer: engaged, invested Explanation: The sentence pivots around the word "thus" and the contrast established by "while." Pundits view declining voting as "civic apathy," but the author suggests "alternative factors" are at play because this decline is actually partnered with "other signs" of citizenship. To contradict "apathy" (lack of interest, enthusiasm, or concern), the blank must describe citizenship that is active or caring. "Engaged" (busy, occupied, or involved) and "invested" (having a devoted or deep-seated interest in something) provide this exact contrast. "Apathetic" repeats the pundits' incorrect view rather than contrasting it. "Docile" (ready to accept control or instruction) and "cynical" (believing that people are motivated by self-interest) describe attitudes that do not directly oppose apathy in a way that demonstrates active citizenship. "Scrupulous" (diligent, thorough, and extremely attentive to details) suggests a moral or exact rigor rather than general civic involvement, and lacks a proper synonym pair among the choices.

SE Question 12

More than the administration’s eager promotion of the new environmental rules, it is the fact that they had excised everyone with bona fide ecological credentials that makes it hardly expected that regulations would be greeted with such _____ by the corporate lobbyists representing the largest polluters.

☐ animus ☐ approbation ☐ hostility ☐ acclaim ☐ trepidation ☐ apathy

Difficulty: 5/5

Correct Answer: animus, hostility Explanation: The sentence requires carefully tracking expectations. The administration "excised" (removed) those with "ecological credentials" from the rule-making process. Logically, removing environmentalists would result in rules favorable to polluters. Therefore, one would expect the "corporate lobbyists representing the largest polluters" to be pleased with the regulations. The blank is preceded by the phrase "hardly expected," meaning the blank must contain a reaction that contradicts this logical assumption. Since they were expected to be happy, the unexpected reaction is anger or opposition. "Animus" (hostility or ill feeling) and "hostility" (unfriendliness or opposition) perfectly capture this unexpected pushback. "Approbation" (approval or praise) and "acclaim" (enthusiastic and public praise) are the expected reactions, making them incorrect for a blank demanding the unexpected outcome. "Trepidation" (a feeling of fear or agitation) implies fear of harm, whereas the lobbyists' influence suggests they are in a position of power, not fear. "Apathy" (lack of interest) does not fit the active nature of the phrasing "greeted with such."

SE Question 13

The recent discovery of the author's extensive marginalia revealed that her prose, long celebrated by critics for its seemingly spontaneous, colloquial flow, was actually the result of highly _____ revision, thoroughly dispelling the myth of her effortless genius. *(Draft: 275 characters)*

☐ painstaking

☐ erratic

☐ meticulous

☐ arbitrary

☐ perfunctory

☐ intuitive

Difficulty: 3/5 Correct Answer: painstaking, meticulous *(NEEDS EXPLANATION)*

SE Question 14 Initially deemed _____, the entomologist's hypothesis regarding the migratory patterns of the monarch butterfly has recently garnered widespread support following a decade of corroborating satellite data. ☐ heretical ☐ orthodox ☐ derivative ☐ heterodox ☐ definitive ☐ unassailable

Difficulty: 3/5 Correct Answers: heretical; heterodox Explanation: The introductory phrase sets up a contrast with "recently garnered widespread support." If it is now supported by data, it must have originally been viewed as going against accepted scientific belief. "Heretical" and "heterodox" both describe views that defy established, orthodox standards.

SE Question 15 Explicitly intended to soothe escalating border tensions, the ambassador's

_____ remarks ironically alienated the very delegates she had sought to appease. ☐ bellicose ☐ placatory ☐ incendiary ☐ pedantic ☐ mollifying ☐ enigmatic

Difficulty: 3/5 Correct Answers: placatory; mollifying Explanation: The blank describes remarks explicitly intended to "soothe escalating border tensions" and "appease" delegates. "Placatory" (intended to make someone less angry or hostile) and "mollifying" (appeasing the anger or anxiety of someone) directly match this specific diplomatic intent.

SE Question 16 While admirers praised the poet's experimentalism as boldly innovative, detractors dismissed the same work as mere _____, arguing that its opacity resulted from pseudo-intellectualism rather than true profundity. ☐ perspicacity ☐ lucidity ☐ mystification ☐ obscurantism ☐ transparency ☐ clarity

Difficulty: 4/5 Correct Answers: mystification; obscurantism Explanation: "Opacity" and "pseudo-intellectualism rather than true profundity" indicate critics view the work as deliberately confusing or needlessly obscure. "Mystification" means the action of utterly bewildering or perplexing someone. "Obscurantism" means the practice of deliberately preventing the facts or full details of something from becoming known. Both words capture the detractors' view that the difficulty is artificial rather than meaningful.

SE Question 17 Often rendering our most advanced astronomical measurements practically _____, the sheer scale of the expanding cosmos reduces staggering galactic distances to mere rounding errors within theoretical physical equations. ☐ momentous ☐ paltry ☐ salient ☐ immutable ☐ meager ☐ convoluted

Difficulty: 3/5 Correct Answers: paltry; meager Explanation: If the staggering distances are reduced to "mere rounding errors," then the measurements relative to the scale of the cosmos are exceptionally small or insignificant. "Paltry" (small or meager) and "meager" (lacking in quantity or quality) fit this dynamic of being overshadowed by immense scale.

SE Question 18 Eschewing the lengthy, discursive personal anecdotes that clutter so many contemporary recipes, the cookbook offered refreshingly _____ instructions that prioritized clear, step-by-step guidance. ☐ verbose ☐ pithy ☐ garrulous ☐ succinct ☐ meandering ☐ grandiloquent

Difficulty: 3/5 Correct Answers: pithy; succinct Explanation: "Eschewing the lengthy, discursive personal anecdotes" in favor of "clear, step-by-step guidance" indicates brevity

and directness. "Pithy" means concise and forcefully expressive. "Succinct" means briefly and clearly expressed. Both words praise the brief, to-the-point instructions.

SE Question 19 Over the course of her career, the novelist's prose style evolved dramatically; where her early works featured _____ sentences laden with subordinate clauses, her mature fiction embraced brevity and directness. ☐ lapidary ☐ tortuous ☐ pithy ☐ involuted ☐ succinct ☐ compact

Difficulty: 3/5 Correct Answers: tortuous; involuted Explanation: "Laden with subordinate clauses" suggests complex, winding sentences that contrast with later "brevity and directness." "Tortuous" means full of twists and turns; excessively lengthy and complex. "Involuted" means highly complicated or intricate. Both describe the elaborate, maze-like quality of the early prose.

SE Question 20 Undeniably brilliant in her vocal execution, the soprano nevertheless delivered the final aria stripped of its tragic depth and rendering a performance so _____ that much of the audience left before it was complete. ☐ histrionic ☐ stolid ☐ volatile ☐ magnetic ☐ impassive ☐ cloying

Difficulty: 4/5 Correct Answers: stolid; impassive Explanation: "Nevertheless" signals a contrast between her "brilliant" vocal execution and her emotional delivery. Because she stripped the aria of its "tragic depth," her presence must have lacked emotion. "Stolid" (calm, dependable, and showing little emotion) and "impassive" (not feeling or showing emotion) perfectly contrast the required passion.

SE Question 21 The industrial designer exhibited a notorious _____; colleagues noted he would spend weeks adjusting a single chair prototype's ergonomic angles until every curve achieved optimal utility. ☐ insouciance ☐ punctiliousness ☐ diffidence ☐ exactitude ☐ temerity ☐ nonchalance

Difficulty: 3/5 Correct Answers: punctiliousness; exactitude Explanation: "Spend weeks adjusting a single chair prototype's ergonomic angles" until it "achieved optimal utility" demonstrates obsessive attention to detail and perfectionism. "Punctiliousness" means showing great attention to detail or correct behavior. "Exactitude" means the quality of being extremely accurate and careful. Both words describe his exacting standards.

SE Question 22 Due to their sparse distribution across the geological stratum, the fragmented remains of the ancient amphibian leave the animal's evolutionary lineage _____. ☐ definitive ☐ nebulous ☐ contiguous ☐ murky ☐ transparent ☐ prolific

Difficulty: 3/5 Correct Answers: nebulous; murky Explanation: The introductory clause explains that the evidence (the fossil record) is fragmented and has a "sparse distribution." Therefore, the lineage cannot be clear. "Nebulous" (unclear, vague, or ill-defined) and "murky" (obscure or difficult to understand) perfectly capture this lack of clarity.

SE Question 23 Due to their sparse distribution across the geological stratum, the fragmented remains of the ancient amphibian leave the animal's evolutionary lineage _____. ☐ definitive ☐ nebulous ☐ contiguous ☐ murky ☐ transparent ☐ prolific

Difficulty: 3/5 Correct Answers: nebulous; murky Explanation: The introductory clause explains that the evidence (the fossil record) is fragmented and has a "sparse distribution." Therefore, the lineage cannot be clear. "Nebulous" (unclear, vague, or ill-defined) and "murky" (obscure or difficult to understand) perfectly capture this lack of clarity.

SE Question 24 The historic property sat incongruously among meticulously manicured stately manors, presenting a _____ appearance. ☐ pristine ☐ manicured ☐ dilapidated ☐ resplendent ☐ derelict ☐ verdant

Difficulty: 3/5 Correct Answers: dilapidated; derelict Explanation: Sitting "incongruously among meticulously manicured stately manors" indicates a sharp visual contrast with pristine estates. "Dilapidated" means in a state of ruin as a result of age or neglect. "Derelict" means in a very poor condition as a result of disuse and neglect. Both words describe the run-down state of the property.

SE Question 25 Famed for elaborate metaphorical names portraying cloying scents as "Dust of Midnight on Etruscan Stone" and "Glimmer of Hope on Mossy Rock," the scented candle company penned notoriously _____ appellations. ☐ severe ☐ spartan ☐ florid ☐ ornate ☐ unadorned ☐ stark

Difficulty: 4/5 Correct Answers: florid; ornate Explanation: "Elaborate metaphorical names" and poetic descriptions indicate highly decorative, flowery language. "Florid" means excessively intricate or elaborate. "Ornate" means elaborately or highly decorated. Both words describe the embellished naming style featuring rich metaphorical language.

SE Question 26 Long considered immutable, the adult brain is now known to exhibit ongoing _____; functional imaging reveals a remarkable capacity to continuously remap neural pathways in response to novel stimuli. ☐ senescence ☐ plasticity ☐ quiescence ☐ fluidity ☐ entropy ☐ rigidity

Difficulty: 4/5 Correct Answers: plasticity; fluidity Explanation: The sentence sets up a pivot from the historical assumption that the brain's structure was "immutable" (unchangeable) to the modern understanding. The capacity to "continuously remap neural pathways" defines a highly adaptable state. "Plasticity" and "fluidity" both capture this constant capacity for structural change and reconfiguration.

SE Question 27 What the board perceived as the director's _____ refusal to compromise on budgetary matters was, in her view, simply a principled stand against cuts that would gut essential programs. ☐ intransigent ☐ flexible ☐ obstinate ☐ accommodating ☐ pliant ☐ amenable

Difficulty: 4/5 Correct Answers: intransigent; obstinate Explanation: "Refusal to compromise" is viewed negatively by the board but seen as principled by the director herself. "Intransigent" means unwilling or refusing to change one's views or to agree about something. "Obstinate" means stubbornly refusing to change one's opinion or chosen course of action. Both describe the uncompromising stance.

SE Question 28 The nineteenth-century textile industry's rapid mechanization met with an entirely _____ resistance in several regions, as local guilds stubbornly refused to adopt power looms despite overwhelming economic incentives. ☐ sporadic ☐ recalcitrant ☐ nominal ☐ progressive ☐ refractory ☐ submissive

Difficulty: 4/5 Correct Answers: recalcitrant; refractory Explanation: The blank must describe the nature of the guilds' resistance, which is defined by them having "stubbornly refused to adopt" the new technology despite obvious incentives. "Recalcitrant" and "refractory" both mean stubbornly resistant to authority, control, or change.

SE Question 29 Although her public statements projected absolute confidence in the peace negotiations, the diplomat's private correspondence revealed a far more _____ assessment of the prospects for agreement. ☐ sanguine ☐ dismal ☐ auspicious ☐ bleak ☐ optimistic ☐ propitious

Difficulty: 3/5 Correct Answers: dismal; bleak Explanation: "Although...projected absolute confidence" but privately revealed something different indicates a contrast between public

optimism and private pessimism. "Dismal" means depressing or dreary. "Bleak" means not hopeful or encouraging. Both words convey the grim, pessimistic private assessment that contrasts with public confidence.

SE Question 30 Once considered _____, the manifesto's authorship has recently been called into serious doubt by modern paleographic analysis and digital imaging techniques. ☐ questionable ☐ incontestable ☐ dubious ☐ incontrovertible ☐ uncertain ☐ ambiguous

Difficulty: 4/5 Correct Answers: incontestable; incontrovertible Explanation: "Once considered...has recently been called into serious doubt" indicates a shift from certainty to uncertainty. "Incontestable" and "incontrovertible" both mean not able to be denied or disputed. Both words indicate the prior state of complete conviction about authorship that has now been challenged.

SE Question 31 Rather than deflecting blame onto subordinates, the CEO chose to accept full responsibility for the product failure, earning widespread respect for what colleagues described as highly _____ leadership. ☐ duplicitous ☐ craven ☐ principled ☐ upright ☐ deceitful ☐ convenient

Difficulty: 2/5 Correct Answers: principled; upright Explanation: Accepting responsibility rather than deflecting blame demonstrates courage and integrity. "Principled" means acting in accordance with morality and showing recognition of right and wrong. "Upright" means strictly honorable or honest. Both words describe the ethical, courageous leadership shown by taking responsibility.

SE Question 32 Issued after contentious deliberation, the Executive Committee's Final Report on Excellence in Education proved disappointingly _____, offering vague recommendations that satisfied no faction and committed to no specific actions. ☐ sharp ☐ incisive ☐ anodyne ☐ innocuous ☐ definitive ☐ unequivocal

Difficulty: 4/5 Correct Answers: anodyne; innocuous Explanation: "Vague recommendations that satisfied no faction" and "committed to no specific actions" indicate a weak, ineffective report that avoids taking any real position. "Anodyne" means not likely to provoke dissent or offense; inoffensive, often deliberately so. "Innocuous" means not harmful or offensive. Both words criticize the report's failure to take a meaningful stand after months of deliberation.

In terms of distribution, let's track and aim for about 26% inference, 26% purpose, 26% ATTP, 15% arguments, and 7% other (select a sentence, contextual definition, etc). In terms of length, let's aim for a final mix of about 15% short (1 question), 42.5% medium (2 questions), and 42.5% long (3 or 4 questions). But during the writing process, let's have 1-2 extra questions written per passage as we may pare some of those down later.

READING COMPREHENSION

Question 1 is based on this passage:

In the nation of Bugonia, economists have noted that an abundance of non-renewable natural resources often leads to lower economic growth in other sectors, a phenomenon known as the "resource curse." A common explanation is that resource exports increase the value of the local currency, making domestic manufacturing uncompetitive globally. However, in Bugonia, the currency has remained stable despite massive oil exports, yet manufacturing has still declined significantly.

1. Which of the following, if true, most helps to resolve the apparent paradox in Bugonia?

   A) The government of Bugonia has historically provided subsidies to the oil industry to maintain its dominance in the global market.

   B) The workforce in Bugonia has shifted toward the high-paying oil sector, creating a localized labor shortage that has increased production costs for factories.

   C) Neighboring nations with fewer natural resources have seen a similar decline in their manufacturing sectors over the same period.

D) The global demand for the specific grade of crude oil exported by Bugonia has increased by 15% over the last decade.

E) The technological infrastructure required for modern manufacturing in Bugonia is more advanced than the infrastructure required for oil extraction.

Difficulty: 4 Correct Answer: B

Explanation:

- (A): Ø What: Subsidies explain oil's success but fail to provide a causal link for manufacturing's decline in a stable-currency environment.
- (B): Correct. This provides an alternative causal mechanism (labor-driven cost increase) that explains the decline without requiring currency appreciation.
- (C): Ø Where: Conditions in neighboring nations do not explain the specific structural paradox within Bugonia.
- (D): Ø What: Demand for oil explains the "abundance" part of the premise but not the "decline in manufacturing" part.
- (E): Ø What: Infrastructure differences do not explain a decline; they merely describe a state of being.

Questions 2–3 are based on this passage

The "Uncanny Valley" hypothesis suggests that as a robot's appearance becomes more human-like, a person's emotional response becomes increasingly positive—until a point is reached in which the response suddenly turns to strong revulsion. This "valley" is often attributed to the brain's inability to reconcile "almost-human" features with non-human movement. However, a recent study showed that toddlers (children aged 12–36 months) do not experience this revulsion when interacting with highly realistic androids, whereas adults in the same study reported high levels of discomfort. Analysts suggest that the primary factors influencing this psychological response are limited to those discussed in the study: social expectation, visual reconciliation, and exposure.

2. Which of the following, if true, most helps to explain the difference in reaction between toddlers and adults?

A) The capacity to identify subtle discrepancies in human facial micro-expressions does not typically manifest in children until after the age of five.

B) The androids used in the study were programmed to speak in high-pitched tones that are naturally soothing to young children.

C) The cognitive processes required to perceive human-like movement are fundamentally different from those used to perceive human-like facial features.

D) Adults are more likely than toddlers to have had exposure to media depictions of robotic technology that emphasize potential malfunctions.

E) Toddlers generally display less fear toward unfamiliar objects than they do toward unfamiliar people.

3. Based on the passage, the author would most likely agree with which of the following regarding the "Uncanny Valley"?

A) It is a universal psychological phenomenon that affects all humans regardless of their stage of biological development.

B) It is triggered primarily by the audible output of an android rather than its physical appearance.

C) It may be a response that requires a certain level of cognitive or social development to manifest.

D) It will eventually be eliminated as robotic movement becomes indistinguishable from human movement.

E) It occurs more frequently in interactions with animals that exhibit human-like behaviors than with androids.

Difficulty: 2 Correct Answer: 2(A), 3(C)

Explanation:

- **2(A):** Correct. This resolves the discrepancy by showing toddlers lack the specific "bar" (detection capacity) that triggers the response in adults.
- **2(B): Ø What:** Sound ≠ "appearance" or "visual reconciliation."
- **2(C): Ø What:** This does not explain the difference between the two groups; it describes a general cognitive state.
- **2(D): Ø Who:** The passage specifically links revulsion to brain reconciliation, not media exposure.
- **2(E): Ø What:** This compares toys to people, whereas the study concerns the "human-like" middle ground.

- **3(A): Too Strong:** "Universal" and "all humans" sets a bar the passage cannot clear because it shows toddlers are an exception.
- **3(B): Too Strong:** "Primarily" is not supported; the passage emphasizes appearance and movement.
- **3(C):** Correct. The low bar set by "may" is cleared because the passage provides a counter-example (toddlers) to a seemingly standard response.
- **3(D): Too Strong:** "Will eventually" is a predictive certainty not found in the text. Ø When.
- **3(E): Too Strong:** "More frequently" creates a comparison to animals not found in the text. Ø What.

Questions 4–7 are based on this passage

Proponents of Modern Monetary Theory (MMT) argue that a government that prints its own sovereign currency cannot go bankrupt. They claim that such a government can fund any social program it chooses simply by issuing more currency. Critics acknowledge that such issuance is legal, but point out that if the supply of money increases faster than the economy's ability to produce goods and services, inflation will spiral out of control. Therefore, the critics conclude, MMT is a dangerous framework that would inevitably lead to total economic collapse.

4. The critics' argument is most vulnerable to criticism on the grounds that it:

   A) Disregards the possibility that social programs may benefit specific demographic groups more than others.

   B) Takes for granted that the primary goal of a government's fiscal policy is to prevent inflation.

   C) Assumes that any increase to a nation's potential economic production derived from programs funded through printed currency will always be lower than the amount by which such printing increases monetary supply.

   D) Ignores historical instances in which hyperinflation occurred in countries that did not follow MMT principles.

   E) Fails to distinguish between the printing of physical currency and the digital creation of credit by central banks.

5. Which of the following, if true, would most strengthen the critics' conclusion?

A) Most citizens in countries considering MMT are willing to tolerate high inflation if it will allow social programs to be greatly expanded.

B) Governments have no policy tools that could be used to remove excess currency from circulation or otherwise reliably control inflation in the face of increased currency supply.

C) Governments with massive debts to foreign nations are equally likely to go bankrupt as are nations that print currency and use it to pay off such debts.

D) The rate of economic growth is influenced by many factors other than the total supply of money.

E) Economic collapse can also be caused by high levels of private debt rather than government spending.

6. The primary purpose of the passage is best described as an attempt to:

A) Resolve a dispute regarding the risks and rewards associated with funding programs directly through expressly printed currency.

B) Demonstrate how both advocates and detractors from a certain policy proposal have based their opinions on information that is incomplete.

C) Argue that the risks associated with a particular proposal are too great to justify the potential benefits.

D) Outline two contrasting beliefs about the degree of risks associated with a certain theoretical policy.

E) Discuss the trade-offs that a government capable of printing its own sovereign currency must consider before funding a given social program.

7. The passage suggests that the proponents and critics of MMT would disagree on which of the following? (Choose all that apply)

▢ The possibility that a government that prints its own sovereign currency could ever reach total economic collapse.

▢ The legitimacy of funding social programs through currency expressly printed for that purpose and entirely ungrounded in taxation or other revenue.

▢ The potential for detrimental impact that inflation can have on a government's ability to print currency.

Difficulty: 5 Correct Answer: 4(C), 5(B), 6(D), 7(First checkbox only)

Explanation:

- **4(A): Ø Who:** Demographic benefits are irrelevant to the "net impact" logic of the inflation argument.
- **4(B):** While the critics prioritize inflation, the argument's vulnerability lies in its causal assumption (the net impact) rather than its prioritization of goals.
- **4(C):** Correct. This identifies the "net impact" flaw: the critics assume the negative (money supply) must always outweigh the positive (productive growth) without proof.
- **4(D): Ø Where:** Instances in non-MMT countries do not invalidate the internal logic of the framework.
- **4(E): Ø What:** The distinction between digital and physical money does not change the inflationary mechanism.
- **5(A): Ø Who:** Citizen willingness to tolerate inflation does not affect the logical validity of whether a collapse will occur.
- **5(B):** Correct. This strengthens the "inevitability" claim by removing any potential counter-measures to control inflation.
- **5(C): Ø What:** This compares bankruptcy causes rather than strengthening the specific causal link of MMT and collapse.
- **5(D): Ø What:** General economic growth factors are too broad to strengthen the specific inflation argument.
- **5(E): Ø What:** Other causes of collapse do not support the critics' specific cause.
- **6(D):** Correct. This accurately summarizes the structure: Proponents (low risk) vs Critics (high risk).
- **7(Checkbox 1):** Correct. Proponents say they "cannot go bankrupt"; critics say it leads to "total economic collapse."
- **7(Checkbox 2):** Incorrect. Both acknowledge it is "legal." The disagreement is on the outcome.
- **7(Checkbox 3): Ø What:** The passage discusses the impact of printing on inflation, not the reverse.

Questions 8–9 are based on this passage

For decades, the liquid electrolyte in lithium-ion batteries has been the industry standard for electric vehicles (EVs). While effective, these batteries pose fire risks if punctured and have limited energy density. Solid-state batteries, which replace the liquid and lithium with a solid ceramic or polymer, promise to increase the range of EVs while being virtually non-flammable. Currently, however, there are two primary obstacles to the rapid commercial rollout of this new technology: durability and cost. Solid-state batteries currently degrade quickly when subjected to the rapid-charging cycles that consumers demand. And manufacturing solid-state batteries currently costs roughly $800 per kilowatt-hour (kWh) to produce, whereas lithium-ion cells have dropped below $150/kWh. Before solid-state technology could achieve market dominance, the manufacturing cost will need to drop significantly below the cost per kilowatt offered by lithium-ion batteries, a feat that most analysts agree will be achieved when ceramic batteries are produced at sufficient scale, sometime between 2030 and 2040.

8. Based on the passage, which of the following can be most reliably inferred?

   A) Sometime after the year 2030, the majority of new vehicles on the road will be powered by solid-state batteries.

   B) The primary advantage of solid-state batteries over liquid electrolyte batteries is their reduced risk of flammability.

   C) Under current technological conditions, a consumer who is not concerned with cost would still almost certainly prefer lithium-ion batteries over solid-state batteries.

   D) If the cost of producing lithium-ion batteries rises rapidly to above the current cost for producing solid-state batteries, solid-state batteries may become the leading commercial option before 2030.

   E) Solid-state batteries have not yet been used in mass-market consumer products such as smartphones or laptops.

9. According to the passage, solid-state batteries differ from lithium-ion batteries in which of the following ways? (Choose all that apply)

   ▢ The type of material used for the electrolyte.

   ▢ The level of risk associated with battery punctures.

   ▢ The current cost of manufacturing at scale.

Difficulty: 4

Correct Answer: 8(D), 9(All three)

Explanation:

- **8(A): Too Strong:** "Will" is a predictive certainty. Ø When.
- **8(B): Too Strong:** "Primary" creates an unprovable hierarchy of advantages.
- **8(C): Too Strong:** "Almost certainly" is a very high bar; some consumers may prioritize safety (non-flammability) over charging durability regardless of cost.
- **8(D):** Correct. The low bar of "may" is cleared by the hypothetical situation in which the cost obstacle is removed, allowing the technology to lead despite remaining obstacles.
- **8(E): Ø What:** The passage only discusses EVs.
- **9:** All three are correct. 1) Liquid vs Solid; 2) Fire risk vs Non-flammable; 3) $150 vs $800.

Questions 10–13 are based on this passage

For much of the history of modern astronomy, the standard models of stellar evolution remained largely unquestioned. These models posit that all stars within a single cluster share a nearly simultaneous birth epoch and should therefore exhibit comparable evolutionary characteristics at any given point in time. However, the discovery of "blue stragglers"—high-mass stars that appear significantly younger and more luminous than their cluster companions—compelled astronomers to reconsider the assumption that observable stellar properties invariably correspond to chronological age. Though several hypotheses were initially proposed to explain this discrepancy, it was not until Steinn Sigurdsson and his colleagues utilized ultraviolet spectroscopy to analyze the cluster 47 Tucanae that a definitive demonstration was achieved. Sigurdsson identified that blue stragglers possessed a unique chemical signature—a depletion of carbon and oxygen relative to neighboring stars. This "hydrodynamic fingerprint" occurs only when material from the deep, thermonuclear interior of one star is spilled onto the surface of another during a physical merger. This process, which Sigurdsson termed "stellar cannibalism," represented a physical mechanism that had never been previously documented. Thus, blue stragglers represent not a refutation of uniform cluster formation but rather evidence of localized dynamical processes that can obscure the relationship between a star's observable features and its true chronology.

10. The primary purpose of the passage is to

    (A) explain how new findings regarding blue stragglers have led to a shift in scientific consensus regarding the validity of the uniform cluster formation model

(B) introduce a novel observational method that identifies the chronological discrepancies between stars in a single birth epoch

(C) describe how an observational inconsistency was reconciled with established models of stellar cluster evolution by explaining a previously undocumented physical mechanism

(D) reevaluate the role of high-density nebular regions in facilitating the sequence of gravitational interactions necessary for binary mergers

(E) challenge the assumption that all stars within a single cluster must possess a specific chemical signature involving carbon and oxygen

11. Which of the following can be most reliably inferred from the passage regarding the "stellar cannibalism" process?

(A) It involves a structural byproduct that allows a high-mass star to maintain its luminous appearance after its hydrogen fuel is depleted.

(B) It occurs with sufficient frequency to ensure that observable stellar properties invariably correspond to chronological age.

(C) It results in a surface chemical composition that provides a more accurate record of a star's physical history than its luminosity provides of its age.

(D) It is a necessary condition for the formation of any high-mass star located within a high-density nebular region.

(E) It represents a localized phenomenon that confirms the late-stage arrival of anomalies within 47 Tucanae.

12. Regarding the stellar merger process, the passage suggests that it

(A) is a process in which a star's physical profile is at variance with the developmental stage expected of the surrounding cluster.

(B) results in a spectroscopic appearance that accurately reflects the age of the cluster rather than the luminosity of the system.

(C) possesses observable features that are more aware of stellar construction than are the features of neighboring stars.

(D) involves the redistribution of material such that the post-merger hydrogen supply is closer to exhaustion than pre-merger appearances would suggest.

(E) represents a phenomenon that had been hypothesized for decades prior to the development of ultraviolet spectroscopy.

13. The author mentions "deep, thermonuclear interior" in order to

(A) provide a comprehensive description of the high-pressure environment where hydrogen fusion primarily occurs within a star's core

(B) argue that the extreme temperatures of the stellar core are responsible for the destabilization of binary orbits

(C) identify the region where carbon and oxygen are typically depleted during the standard evolutionary life cycle of a single star

(D) explain the specific origin of the chemical markers that provide empirical proof of the stellar cannibalism hypothesis

(E) demonstrate that blue stragglers possess a greater concentration of unspent hydrogen than do their neighboring cluster members

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Difficulty Tier: 5

Correct Answers: 10. **(C)** 11. **(C)** 12. **(A)** 13. **(D)**

Explanations:

10(A): Too Strong. While the passage mentions "reconsidering" an assumption, the final sentence explicitly clarifies that the discovery is *not* a refutation of the uniform model. The consensus on the model itself remains; only the interpretation of the specific anomaly shifted.

10(B): Too Narrow. While ultraviolet spectroscopy is the tool used, the passage’s primary intent is to explain the *reconciliation* of a standard theory with an anomaly, not merely to introduce a method.

10(C): Correct. This identifies the "blue straggler" anomaly and explains how Sigurdsson's discovery of "cannibalism" allowed the observation to be integrated into established models rather than overturning them.

10(D): Ø What: The passage focuses on the *outcome* and chemical evidence of the merger, not a documentation of the "sequence" of interactions that led to it.

10(E): Ø What: The author does not challenge the assumption that stars *should* have these signatures; they explain *why* blue stragglers specifically lack them.

11(A): Word-Salad Trap. This incorrectly suggests fuel is "depleted" when the text states the merger introduces a "substantial reservoir" of *unprocessed* fuel.

11(B): Direct Contradiction. The passage states that the process *obscures* the relationship between properties and age, rather than ensuring they "invariably correspond."

11(C): Correct. This utilizes the "Mathematical Inversion" logic: the observable luminosity "belies" or "obscures" the age, while the chemical signature provides the "definitive demonstration" of the star's physical history.

11(D): Necessary vs. Sufficient. The text describes blue stragglers as products of this process, but never states it is a "necessary condition" for the formation of *all* high-mass stars in such regions.

11(E): Direct Contradiction. The author explicitly rejects the "late-stage arrival" theory in the middle of the passage.

12(A): Correct. This rests on the "it = merger process" link. The process is defined as the cause of the variance between a star's physical profile and the expected cluster age.

12(B): Pronoun Trap. This option describes the *cluster* or the *standard model*, but the "it" (the merger process) does the opposite: it makes the star's appearance *younger* than the cluster age.

12(C): Categorical Error. Observable features cannot be "aware" of stellar construction.

12(D): Direct Contradiction. The passage states the merger *introduces* hydrogen fuel; "exhaustion" would be the state *prior* to the merger.

12(E): Ø When: The passage states the mechanism had "never been previously documented," undermining the claim that it was hypothesized for decades.

13(A): What vs. Why: While technically an accurate description of a thermonuclear interior, this is not the *reason* the author included the detail in this specific argument.

13(B): Causal Trap. The passage attributes the destabilization to "gravitational perturbations," not the internal temperature of the core.

13(C): Direct Contradiction. The passage frames this depletion as a "unique" signature of mergers, not a standard stage of a single star's life cycle.

13(D): Correct. The author points to this region to explain the source of the chemical markers (carbon/oxygen depletion) that serve as empirical proof that a merger occurred.

13(E): Displaced Target. The mention of the "deep interior" specifically relates to the *depletion* of chemicals, not the *concentration* of hydrogen.

Questions 14–18 are based on this passage

Psychological investigations into the "Foreign Language Effect" suggest that the linguistic medium through which a moral dilemma is processed acts as a significant mediator of ethical output. When presented with the "Trolley Problem"—a scenario requiring an active choice between allowing five people to perish or intervening to sacrifice one—bilingual subjects are significantly more likely to favor the utilitarian outcome when using their non-native tongue. This shift persists regardless of whether the subject has attained a high level of proficiency in the secondary language. Researchers, led by Albert Costa, hypothesize that the cognitive effort required to process a non-native language dampens the immediate, visceral response that typically supports deontological prohibitions against causing harm.

In this respect, the linguistic "buffer" provided by a second language appears to function in the same manner as other spatial and psychological distancing effects described by the philosopher Peter Singer and the neuroscientist Joshua Greene. Singer, in his arguments for the universal moral obligations that humans have to one another, observes that while most individuals would unquestionably rescue a drowning child in their immediate vicinity, a similar impulse becomes more readily ignored when the victim is geographically remote, even if the sacrifice required (ruining clothes vs. a marginal financial contribution to medical care) is identical. Greene's related neuroimaging research suggests a neurological basis for this difference. He posed the same Trolley Problem above in two forms: when framed as "a switch that the participant can flip that will kill one person in order to save 5," participants were far more likely to endorse a utilitarian sacrifice than when the act required physically pushing a victim into the path of danger to save the 5 others. But interestingly, not only were the results different, but the actual brain activity diverged significantly as well.

This led to Greene's "dual-process" model, in which the brain has two distinct decision-making engines. When triggered by the visceral emotional pull of "personal" harm, the amygdala is activated and overrides any logical analysis with an immediate and definitive activation of a basic "no harm" rule. Conversely, when the brain feels sufficiently distanced from the visceral aspects of

the "crisis," the prefrontal cortex assumes a detached, calculating perspective, shifting the neural burden from instinctive alarm to cost-benefit analysis.

14. The primary purpose of the passage as a whole is to

(A) examine how diverse frameworks of linguistic processing and moral psychology can be synthesized to explain variations in ethical judgment

(B) argue that the "Foreign Language Effect" and Greene's "dual-process" model are fundamentally the same phenomenon

(C) describe how an observational inconsistency was reconciled with established models of neurobiology by explaining a previously undocumented physical mechanism

(D) introduce a novel observational method for measuring the specific neural signatures involved in binary ethical decisions

(E) reevaluate the means by which the use of a non-native language influences the application of specific moral theories

15. In the context of the passage as a whole, the author most likely included the first paragraph in order to

(A) identify the specific linguistic conditions under which a certain anomalous behavior occurs

(B) explain the way that researchers believed a certain process to work before their model was updated to reflect new insight from advanced neuroimagery

(C) introduce a phenomenon that serves as one example of a broader decision making pattern

(D) illustrate the tendency towards "emotional proximity" that is characteristic of questions raised in an individual's primary linguistic medium

(E) introduce the "Trolley Problem" as the preeminent conceptual framework within which dual decision making processes can be discussed

16. According to the passage, the likelihood of an individual making a utilitarian choice could potentially be influenced by all of the following EXCEPT

(A) the specific physical means by which the individual intervenes in a moral crisis

(B) the individual's intuitive rejection of causing active harm overriding their ability to conduct a standard cost-benefit analysis

(C) the level of proficiency the individual has attained in the relevant physical, mechanical, technical, or linguistic medium

(D) the extent to which the individual's decision-making structure is activated by the emotional resonance of a native tongue

(E) the degree to which a communicative context provides the individual with a psychological buffer from visceral emotion

17. Which of the following can be most reliably inferred from the passage regarding a bilingual individual using their native language?

(A) Their amygdala is somewhat more likely to override logical analysis than would be the case were they faced with a similar decision presented in a second language.

(B) Their moral judgments are made with more awareness of cognitive construction than are the judgments of bilingual individuals using a secondary language.

(C) They would be no more able to reach a utilitarian conclusion if the same dilemma were presented with greater physical or mechanical distancing.

(D) They are unlikely to make a decision that requires them to violate any inhibition they may have against causing direct physical harm.

(E) The cognitive effort they require to translate abstract rules into utilitarian outcomes will be much less than that required by a monolingual counterpart.

18. The passage suggests that Peter Singer and Joshua Greene would most likely agree that (Select all that apply)

▢ Moral decision-making can be altered significantly by factors that are not inherent to the ethical content of the dilemma itself.

▢ Physical and emotional distance can lead humans to make morally dubious decisions.

▢ Secondary languages can, in bilingual adults, act as a distancing effect that may alter the individual's conception of obligation and morality.

Difficulty Tier: 5

Correct Answers: 14. **(A)** 15. **(C)** 16. **(C)** 17. **(A)** 18. **(First checkbox only)**

Explanations:

Questions 14–18: Foreign Language Effect

14. The primary purpose of the passage as a whole is to

- **(A) Correct.** This accurately synthesizes the entire text: it bridges the linguistic observations of paragraph one (Costa) with the philosophical (Singer) and neurological (Greene) frameworks of paragraph two to explain variations in judgment.
- **(B) False Pivot.** The passage treats the "Foreign Language Effect" and the "Dual-Process" model as complementary or analogous frameworks, but it does not argue they are the *exact same* phenomenon.
- **(C) Ø What.** This describes the reconciliation of a "previously undocumented" mechanism. The theories here are presented as established frameworks used to explain a phenomenon, not as a resolution of a specific scientific "inconsistency."
- **(D) Too Narrow.** While neuroimaging is mentioned, the passage is an inquiry into ethical judgment and linguistics, not merely the "introduction of a novel method."
- **(E) Too Narrow.** This is a "Paragraph 1" trap. While the passage does reevaluate the influence of language, this choice fails to encompass the second paragraph's expansion into spatial and mechanical distancing.

15. In the context of the passage as a whole, the author most likely included the first paragraph in order to

- **(A) Ø What.** While the paragraph identifies linguistic conditions, its primary function within the *whole* passage is to set up the phenomenon that the second paragraph then explains neurologically.
- **(B) Ø When.** The passage doesn't suggest a previous "incorrect" belief was updated by "advanced neuroimagery"; rather, Greene provided a neurological basis for an observed difference.
- **(C) Correct.** The first paragraph introduces the Foreign Language Effect, which serves as the specific case study (the "one example") for the "broader pattern" of dual-process decision-making explained in the second paragraph.
- **(D) Too Narrow.** This is a detail found in Paragraph 2 ("emotional proximity"), and it does not capture the function of Paragraph 1 as an introduction to the linguistic effect.

- **(E) Too Strong.** The "Trolley Problem" is a tool used by researchers, but the passage never labels it the "preeminent" or only framework for discussion.

16. According to the passage, the likelihood of an individual making a utilitarian choice could potentially be influenced by all of the following EXCEPT

- **(A) Influences.** This maps to the "switch vs. push" evidence; the physical means of intervention determines the ethical output.
- **(B) Influences.** This maps to the "personal harm" and "amygdala" logic; personal harm overrides logical analysis.
- **(C) Correct.** The passage explicitly states the effect "persists regardless of whether the subject has attained a high level of proficiency." Therefore, proficiency is the one factor listed that does *not* influence the likelihood of the choice.
- **(D) Influences.** This maps to the "native tongue" and "emotional resonance" logic; the activation of the amygdala influences the choice.
- **(E) Influences.** This maps to the "linguistic buffer" and "spatial distance" logic; these provide the distance that allows for a calculating perspective.

17. Which of the following can be most reliably inferred from the passage regarding a bilingual individual using their native language?

- **(A) Correct.** The passage links the native tongue to "emotional resonance" and "proximity," which triggers the amygdala to override logic. Therefore, that structure is more likely to override analysis in a native tongue than in a second language, where the "buffer" dampens that response.
- **(B) Ø What.** "Awareness of cognitive construction" is a concept not discussed or supported by the text's analysis of neural structures.
- **(C) Too Strong.** While distancing makes a utilitarian conclusion *more likely*, the passage doesn't suggest that a lack of distance makes it impossible for an individual to reach one.
- **(D) ARM (Absolute vs Relative Metric) Trap.** The passage establishes a relative increase in the likelihood of utilitarian choices in a second language compared to a native one. While this confirms the amygdala is *more* likely to override logic in the native tongue than otherwise (a relative comparison), it does not provide enough data to establish an absolute status as likely to override. Saying a subject is "unlikely" to violate an inhibition is an absolute claim about their behavior that the passage, which focuses only on the *shifting* of probability, never clears.
- **(E) Unwarranted Comparison.** The passage compares an individual using a native vs. foreign tongue; it does not compare the "cognitive effort" of bilinguals against "monolingual counterparts."

18. The passage suggests that Peter Singer and Joshua Greene would most likely agree that (Select all that apply)

- **(Checkbox 1) Correct.** Both suggest external mediators (perceived distance, mechanical means) influence the decision, independent of the actual ethical content of the dilemma.
- **(Checkbox 2) Ø What.** This is a value judgment ("morally dubious"). Though there is some indication that Peter Singer would agree with this, there is no indication that Joshua Greene would.
- **(Checkbox 3) Source Trap.** While the *author* uses Singer to explain the linguistic effect, the passage does not claim Singer himself commented on "secondary languages" or "bilingual adults."

Questions 19–22 are based on this passage

The Younger Dryas was a period of abrupt climate cooling occurring roughly 12,900 years ago, characterized by a sudden return to glacial conditions that interrupted the warming trend of the late Pleistocene. While this cooling was historically attributed to internal oceanic shifts—specifically the shutdown of the Atlantic meridional overturning circulation due to meltwater—the discovery of "black mats" has compelled a reconsideration of this narrative. These carbon-rich layers, found at various sites across North America and Europe, contain nanodiamonds and iridium: markers typically associated with extraterrestrial impact. Geologists, led by James Kennett, have proposed the "Younger Dryas Impact Hypothesis," suggesting that a large bolide struck the North American ice sheet.

Critics of the hypothesis point to the lack of a primary impact crater as a definitive refutation. However, Kennett argues that the comet likely struck ice up to three kilometers thick, which acted as a protective shield for the terrestrial surface. In this model, the ice absorbed the kinetic energy of the strike and melted instantaneously, releasing a catastrophic volume of freshwater into the North Atlantic. This influx provided the trigger for the oceanic shutdown without requiring a terrestrial crater. Thus, to Kennett the missing crater represents not a refutation of an impact but evidence of a physical mechanism that can obscure the structural record of a cataclysmic event.

19. The primary purpose of the passage is to

    (A) explain how one theory attempts to reconcile the presence of one type of evidence with the absence of another type of evidence normally associated with it

(B) demonstrate how new findings regarding the Younger Dryas have led to a shift in scientific consensus regarding the duration of glacial epochs

(C) argue that the "Impact Hypothesis" and the "Meltwater Model" are mutually exclusive explanations for the same cooling event

(D) advocate for the widespread acceptance of a previously undocumented physical mechanism

(E) challenge the assumption that terrestrial craters are a necessary condition for validating a cataclysmic impact theory

20. In the context of the passage as a whole, the author most likely mentions "three kilometers thick" in order to

(A) identify the specific physical conditions that prevented the formation of a permanent terrestrial record of the bolide

(B) explain the way that researchers believed the ice sheet to work before their model was updated to reflect new findings

(C) illustrate the tendency towards "structural obscurity" that is characteristic of questions raised in a primary geological medium

(D) provide a contextual framework for understanding why the melting of the ice sheet was a mathematical necessity

(E) establish a conceptual framework within which the lack of a primary crater can be discussed as evidence rather than refutation

21. The passage suggests that the likelihood of a terrestrial impact crater being discovered following a bolide strike is potentially influenced by which of the following? (Select all that apply)

▢ The thickness of the ice sheet relative to the kinetic energy of the striking bolide.

▢ The extent to which a cataclysmic event is obscured by the rapid melting of a protective shield.

▢ The internal chemical properties of the North American ice sheet during the late Pleistocene.

22. Which of the following can be most reliably inferred from the passage regarding the "black mats"?

(A) Their chemical profile is somewhat more likely to be found in regions that did not experience an abrupt return to glacial conditions.

(B) They provide an unambiguous physical record of bolide impact.

(C) They represent a feature whose presence is unexplained by the historical narrative of purely internal oceanic climate shifts.

(D) They are unlikely to be found in regions that did not experience an abrupt return to glacial conditions roughly 12,900 years ago.

(E) They contain physical evidence that provides a more accurate record of physical impact than the terrestrial landscape would.

Difficulty Tier: 5 Correct Answers: 19. (A) 20. (A) 21. (Boxes 1 and 2 only) 22. (E)

19. The primary purpose of the passage is to

- **(A) Correct.** This accurately summarizes the macro-logic of the text: Kennett utilizes the presence of one type of evidence (the "black mats" and their chemical markers) to explain away the absence of the evidence usually expected of such an event (the terrestrial crater).
- **(B) Ø What.** While the passage discusses the discovery of "black mats," it describes a shift in the perceived *cause* of the cooling (impact vs. oceanic shift), not a change in the consensus regarding the *duration* of the epoch.
- **(C) False Pivot.** The passage does not frame these as mutually exclusive; rather, it suggests the "Impact Hypothesis" provides the *trigger* for the "Meltwater Model" (oceanic shutdown).
- **(D) Advocate vs. Explain.** The authorial tone is explanatory. While the passage presents Kennett's hypothesis, it does so to describe the theoretical reconciliation of data rather than to "advocate" for its general acceptance.
- **(E) Too Strong.** Reevaluating the "necessary condition" of craters is a logical step within the argument, but the primary purpose is the broader reconciliation of the conflicting evidence types.

20. In the context of the passage as a whole, the author most likely mentions "three kilometers thick" in order to

- **(A) Correct.** This identifies the specific physical "why": the thickness of the ice sheet is the condition that prevented a permanent terrestrial record (a crater) from being etched into the land.
- **(B) Ø When.** The passage does not suggest that the previous model failed because it misunderstood the ice sheet; rather, the new finding (black mats) required a new explanation for why a crater was missing.
- **(C) Ø What.** The ice thickness is cited to explain a lack of evidence, not to serve as an example of "glacial expansion."
- **(D) Word-Salad Trap.** "Structural obscurity" and "primary geological medium" are phrases adapted from other contexts that do not accurately describe the author's intent here.
- **(E) Correct.** This captures the structural rhetorical goal: the detail allows the "missing crater" to be discussed as a predictable result of a specific mechanism (evidence) rather than as a failure of the theory (refutation).

21. The passage suggests that the likelihood of a terrestrial impact crater being discovered following a bolide strike is potentially influenced by which of the following? (Select all that apply)

- **(Checkbox 1) Correct.** The passage notes that the "three kilometers" (thickness) relative to the "kinetic energy" determines whether the shield is sufficient to protect the terrestrial surface and prevent crater formation.
- **(Checkbox 2) Correct.** The "instantaneous melting" of the shield is the specific process that "obscures the structural record," thereby influencing whether a crater is discovered.
- **(Checkbox 3) Ø What.** While the passage mentions the *physical* properties of the ice (thickness), it does not suggest that the *internal chemical properties* of the ice had any influence on the formation or discovery of a terrestrial crater.

22. Which of the following can be most reliably inferred from the passage regarding the "black mats"? *

- **(A) Ø Where.** The passage states they were found at sites of abrupt cooling, but it does not provide evidence to suggest they would be *more likely* to be found where cooling did *not* occur.
- **(B) Too Strong.** The term "unambiguous" is too definitive; the passage presents them as markers that "compelled a reconsideration," not as an absolute, closed case.
- **(C) ARM (Relative vs. Absolute) Trap.** While the mats are "at variance" with the *old* narrative (purely internal oceanic shifts), the phrase "unexplained by" is an absolute claim. The historical narrative might not have *included* them, but the passage doesn't prove the old model is incapable of explaining them.

- **(D) ARM (Absolute) Trap.** The passage links the mats to sites that cooled 12,900 years ago, but it does not provide enough data to establish the absolute status that they are "unlikely" to be found elsewhere or from other periods.
- **(E) Correct.** This is a **Mathematical Inversion** (Record of History vs. Record of Location). The mats provide a "more accurate record" that the impact *happened* (physical occurrence) than the landscape provides of *where* it happened (location), due to the missing crater.

RESOLVE / EXPLAIN

Despite the fact that very large firms (with over 2,000 employees and over 100,000 customers) are subject to extensive cybersecurity audits from which small (under 5,000 customers and under 100 employees) and moderate sized firms (5,000 - 50,000 customers and 100-500 employees) are exempt, a greater number of reported data breaches originate from large corporations than from small and moderate sized businesses.

Which of the following, if true, helps explain the apparent paradox?

A. Small and moderate businesses rely more heavily on third-party software providers than large corporations do.
B. Large corporations employ significantly more sophisticated encryption systems than small firms do.
C. Longstanding federal statutes require reporting of any data breaches detected during a cybersecurity audit.
D. Small firms experience fewer cyberattacks overall than large corporations.
E. As a group, small and moderate sized firms store data on a larger number of customers than do large corporations.

Correct Answer: C

Hospital-based screenings for Pertussis are generally more thorough than community-based screenings, and resultingly, are far less likely to produce a false positive result and no more likely to produce a false negative result. But a recently released national study showed that the percent of the patients in hospitals who had been cleared as free of Pertussis and later found to actually carry it was much higher than the corresponding percent for those who took part in community based screenings.

Which of the following, if true, best explains this surprising result?

A. Community Pertussis screenings are no more likely to miss early-stage cases, but are somewhat more likely to miss late-stage cases.
B. Ready access to necessary equipment in most hospitals means thatHospital patients are substantially more likely to be tested for Pertussis multiple times.
C. Community Pertussis screening programs more often rely on voluntary participation, whereas hospital Pertussis screens can be required of Patients who would not have participated voluntarily.

D. Hospital populations do not tend to underrepresent groups with the lowest Pertussis risk-factors.

E. Though these statistics may hold true for the average hospital-based Pertussis screenings, there may be some hospitals that use processes that yield results which are effectively identical to those yielded in the most accurate community based Pertussis screenings.

Correct Answer: B

(5/5 difficulty)

READING COMPREHENSION

Questions 7–9 are based upon the following passage.

In both formal writing and informal discussions, the term “model” is frequently applied to a wide range of representational tools, from schematic diagrams to mathematical abstractions. This breadth of usage can obscure meaningful distinctions among the purposes such models serve. Some are designed primarily to generate reliable predictions, others to illuminate causal relationships, and still others to organize phenomena that resist direct observation. When these differences are overlooked, a model may be unfairly criticized for failing to accomplish an objective it was never intended to pursue.

(7) The primary purpose of the passage is to:

(A) argue that predictive accuracy is more important to scientific explanation than accomplishing objectives
(B) illustrate the means by which scientific models would ideally function
(C) question the validity of considering aspects of a model’s utility other than those which it was designed to achieve
(D) outline a risk associated with failing to distinguish among a variety of concepts and intentions
(E) resolve the ambiguity that otherwise prevents accurate judgements of representational tools

	Explanation: This passage explains how a wide range of things are all called “models”, despite meaningful distinctions in purpose, and how this can lead to unfair criticism of some models because of the expectation that they should do something that a different type of model might, but that is not their intent. For (A), there is nothing that offers a ranking of the importance of “predictive accuracy” over “accomplishing objectives”: this is “word soup” pulled from the passage without matching the meaning or intent of the passage. (B) is somewhat tempting because the entire passage is about models and implicitly about how to improve our understanding of them, but it is neither focused on “function” nor on “ideal means”, but rather on the negatives associated with the current usage. (C) Has a lot going for it: the author is concerned about evaluating a model without regard for the goals that it was designed to achieve. But the author isn’t so much “questioning” the validity of that as pointing out how that is a downside associated with the overly broad usage of the term. (D) “Outline” better captures the neutral narrative tone used in this passage than most of our other options; “risk” is an appropriate way to describe the focus of the text; and though models are not mentioned by name, the central issue with models is clearly spelled out. (E) The author is more focused on describing the ambiguity than resolving it; additionally, saying that this ambiguity “prevents accurate judgements of representational tools” goes beyond the scope of the

	passage. **Correct Answer**: D. (Difficulty: 3/5)
Questions 7–9 are based upon the following passage. In both formal writing and informal discussions, the term “model” is frequently applied to a wide range of representational tools, from schematic diagrams to mathematical abstractions. This breadth of usage can obscure meaningful distinctions among the purposes such models serve. Some are designed primarily to generate reliable predictions, others to illuminate causal relationships, and still others to organize phenomena that resist direct observation. When these differences are overlooked, a model may be unfairly criticized for failing to accomplish an objective it was never intended to pursue.	(8) Which of the following does the passage suggest would be likely to serve as examples of misplaced criticisms of models? ☐ Treating a mathematical function as though it could explain causal relationships ☐ Expecting a schematic diagram for a luxury sedan to offer insight into the workings of a luxury SUV produced by the same manufacturer ☐ Imagining that a model for the vector-borne spread of infectious diseases would be applicable in determining which pieces of digital media were most likely to spread widely **Explanation:** The passage raises a concern about anytime something is evaluated based on a standard

	outside of that which it was intended to serve. (A) Could create such an issue, but there is no reason to assume that this is outside of the intended scope of the mathematical function, so do not choose this answer. (B) Shows an object created with one intention (showing the schematics of a luxury car) being expected to perform another (show the workings of a different vehicle). This is exactly the risk that the author describes, select this answer. (C) The model was made for disease and here is applied to digital media; again, this is exactly what the author was concerned about. Select this one as well. **Correct Answer:** (B) and (C) but not (A). (Difficulty: 4/5)
Questions 7–9 are based upon the following passage. In both formal writing and informal discussions, the term “model” is frequently applied to a wide range of representational tools, from schematic diagrams to mathematical abstractions. This breadth of usage can obscure meaningful distinctions among the purposes such models serve. Some are designed primarily to generate reliable predictions, others to illuminate causal relationships, and still others to organize phenomena that resist direct observation. When these differences are overlooked, a model may be unfairly criticized for failing to accomplish an objective it was never intended to pursue.	Question 9 According to the passage, misplaced criticisms of scientific models would be most likely to result from which of the following? (A) An expectation that a greatly simplified model composed of rows and columns could illuminate complex relationships that may be non-linear and not mutually exclusive. (B) A negative experience with a particularly obscure model that is atypically unhelpful compared to other, better organized models. (C) A futile attempt to create categories from phenomena that resist direct categorization. (D) An attempt to use a model designed for addressing a particular concern for any purpose outside of explicitly addressing that concern. (E) An overly broad sense of what a model is, such that expectations that would be appropriate for an actual model are projected on a representational tool that is not, in fact, a model.

	(Difficulty: 3/5) Correct Answers: - Treating all models as though they are intended to explain causal mechanisms - Expecting a model to perform functions beyond its original design Explanation: Both correct answers restate the passage's core logic. The most tempting incorrect option concerns the practical utility of abstractions, which the passage does not discuss.
Coral Reefs occupy just 1% of the seafloor but support over 25% of all marine life, contribute to the livelihood of over 1 billion humans, and offer vital protection from storm surges that increasingly threaten many coastal regions. But many of our remaining reefs are periodically decimated during even relatively brief periods in which seawater temperatures rise beyond that in which the delicate reef ecosystems are possible. When marine ecologists set out to understand coral reef recovery following thermal bleaching events, they tracked two observable phenomena: the return of coral polyp colonies and the reappearance of reef fish populations. Current consensus models emphasize that reef structural complexity—created by coral growth—is the necessary precondition for fish communities to recolonize areas Biologists, such as Dr. Pichomen and Dr. Koralla, have traditionally studied reefs by monitoring reef sites across the Indo-Pacific following major bleaching episodes, documenting coral	**Question 3.1: Main Purpose** The primary purpose of the passage is to **A.** Outline a situation in which new information threatens a consensus view of how an important ecosystem recovers from episodic challenges.

regrowth rates and fish population dynamics. Field observations at several recently bleached sites initially seemed to confirm expectations: coral colonies regrew slowly, and fish populations returned only after sufficient coral cover had been reestablished. Recently, a new technique pioneered by Professor Glossamin is focused on analyzing sediment core samples that preserve chemical signatures of historical biodiversity, which she calls paleobiological markers. In the periods following many historical reef disturbances, the paleobiological markers show diverse fish assemblages often established themselves in degraded reef environments before coral recovery had progressed beyond minimal levels. In some cases, fish communities reached peak diversity when coral cover remained below 15%—far lower than current consensus models would predict as viable. Dr. Pichomen has argued that this suggests prevailing theories about reef recovery have the dependency relationship reversed: rather than coral complexity enabling fish communities, it may be that certain fish behaviors actively facilitate coral larval settlement and polyp survival, meaning fish-first colonization could accelerate rather than follow from coral recovery. But Dr. Koralla, in his most recent paper, makes a compelling empirical case that neither the consensus model nor Dr. Pichomen's newer theory can adequately explain the apparent change in sequencing, and proposes further research into whether differences in ocean salinity may explain the results. In recent years, rising global temperatures have led to increased evaporation in many shallow tropical waters historically hospital to coral reefs (effectively concentrating the existing salt), and decreasing in other historic reef zones in which increased freshwater runoff from nearby landmasses is diluting salinity.	**B.** describe competing methodologies for studying coral reef resilience after disturbances due to rising ocean temperatures **C.** argue that seawater salinity offers a more compelling explanation than seawater temperature for the variety of coral reef regeneration processes **D.** explain why many contemporary reef monitoring efforts have tended to produce questionable results **E.** propose that further research is necessary to determine the complex causal relationship between fish diversity and coral reef structural complexity

	Difficulty: 5/5 (A? But deliberately a close call)
Coral Reefs occupy just 1% of the seafloor but support over 25% of all marine life, contribute to the livelihood of over 1 billion humans, and offer vital protection from storm surges that increasingly threaten many coastal regions. But many of our remaining reefs are periodically decimated during even relatively brief periods in which seawater temperatures rise beyond that in which the delicate reef ecosystems are possible. When marine ecologists set out to understand coral reef recovery following thermal bleaching events, they tracked two observable phenomena: the return of coral polyp colonies and the reappearance of reef fish populations. Current consensus models emphasize that reef structural complexity—created by coral growth—is the necessary precondition for fish communities to recolonize areas Biologists, such as Dr. Pichomen and Dr. Koralla, have traditionally studied reefs by monitoring reef sites across the Indo-Pacific following major bleaching episodes, documenting coral regrowth rates and fish population dynamics. Field observations at several recently bleached sites initially seemed to confirm expectations: coral colonies regrew slowly, and fish populations returned only after sufficient coral cover had been reestablished. Recently, a new technique pioneered by Professor Glossamin is focused on analyzing sediment core samples that preserve chemical signatures of historical biodiversity, which she calls paleobiological markers. In the periods following many historical reef disturbances, the paleobiological markers show diverse fish assemblages often established themselves in degraded reef environments before coral recovery had progressed beyond minimal levels. In some cases, fish communities reached peak diversity when coral cover remained below 15%—far lower than current consensus models would predict as viable. Dr. Pichomen has argued that this suggests prevailing theories about reef recovery have the dependency relationship reversed: rather than coral complexity enabling fish communities, it may be that certain fish behaviors actively facilitate coral larval settlement and polyp survival, meaning fish-first colonization could accelerate rather than follow from coral recovery. But Dr. Koralla, in his most recent paper, makes a compelling empirical case that neither the consensus model nor Dr. Pichomen's newer theory can adequately explain the apparent change in sequencing, and proposes further research into whether differences in ocean salinity may explain the results. In recent years, rising global temperatures have led to increased evaporation in many shallow tropical waters	**Question 3.2: Inference (Select all that apply)** Consider each of the choices separately and select all that apply. The passage suggests which of the following about reef recovery processes? ☐ Field observations of recently bleached reefs may not capture the full range of recovery pathways available to reef ecosystems. ☐ Contemporary consensus models of reef recovery are more compatible with the data from the most recent reef recoveries than they are with data from much older eras of regrowth. ☐ Fish behavior can influence coral survival under certain environmental conditions.

historically hospital to coral reefs (effectively concentrating the existing salt), and decreasing in other historic reef zones in which increased freshwater runoff from nearby landmasses is diluting salinity.	**Difficulty: 4/5** A yes, B yes, C no
Coral Reefs occupy just 1% of the seafloor but support over 25% of all marine life, contribute to the livelihood of over 1 billion humans, and offer vital protection from storm surges that increasingly threaten many coastal regions. But many of our remaining reefs are periodically decimated during even relatively brief periods in which seawater temperatures rise beyond that in which the delicate reef ecosystems are possible. When marine ecologists set out to understand coral reef recovery following thermal bleaching events, they tracked two observable phenomena: the return of coral polyp colonies and the reappearance of reef fish populations. Current consensus models emphasize that reef structural complexity—created by coral growth—is the necessary precondition for fish communities to recolonize areas Biologists, such as Dr. Pichomen and Dr. Koralla, have traditionally studied reefs by monitoring reef sites across the Indo-Pacific following major bleaching episodes, documenting coral regrowth rates and fish population dynamics. Field observations at several recently bleached sites	**Question 3.3: Contextual Definition** In the context in which it appears, "viable" most nearly means **A.** sustainable **B.** observable **C.** diverse **D.** typical

initially seemed to confirm expectations: coral colonies regrew slowly, and fish populations returned only after sufficient coral cover had been reestablished. Recently, a new technique pioneered by Professor Glossamin is focused on analyzing sediment core samples that preserve chemical signatures of historical biodiversity, which she calls paleobiological markers. In the periods following many historical reef disturbances, the paleobiological markers show diverse fish assemblages often established themselves in degraded reef environments before coral recovery had progressed beyond minimal levels. In some cases, fish communities reached peak diversity when coral cover remained below 15%—far lower than current consensus models would predict as viable. Dr. Pichomen has argued that this suggests prevailing theories about reef recovery have the dependency relationship reversed: rather than coral complexity enabling fish communities, it may be that certain fish behaviors actively facilitate coral larval settlement and polyp survival, meaning fish-first colonization could accelerate rather than follow from coral recovery. But Dr. Koralla, in his most recent paper, makes a compelling empirical case that neither the consensus model nor Dr. Pichomen's newer theory can adequately explain the apparent change in sequencing, and proposes further research into whether differences in ocean salinity may explain the results. In recent years, rising global temperatures have led to increased evaporation in many shallow tropical waters historically hospital to coral reefs (effectively concentrating the existing salt), and decreasing in other historic reef zones in which increased freshwater runoff from nearby landmasses is diluting salinity.	**E.** possible

	Difficulty: 3/5 E.
Coral Reefs occupy just 1% of the seafloor but support over 25% of all marine life, contribute to the livelihood of over 1 billion humans, and offer vital protection from storm surges that increasingly threaten many coastal regions. But many of our remaining reefs are periodically decimated during even relatively brief periods in which seawater temperatures rise beyond that in which the delicate reef ecosystems are possible. When marine ecologists set out to understand coral reef recovery following thermal bleaching events, they tracked two observable phenomena: the return of coral polyp colonies and the reappearance of reef fish populations. Current consensus models emphasize that reef structural complexity—created by coral growth—is the necessary precondition for fish communities to recolonize areas Biologists, such as Dr. Pichomen and Dr. Koralla, have traditionally studied reefs by monitoring reef sites across the Indo-Pacific following major bleaching episodes, documenting coral regrowth rates and fish population dynamics. Field observations at several recently bleached sites initially seemed to confirm expectations: coral colonies regrew slowly, and fish populations returned only after sufficient coral cover had been reestablished. Recently, a new technique pioneered by Professor Glossamin is focused on analyzing sediment core samples that preserve chemical signatures of historical biodiversity, which she calls paleobiological markers. In the periods following many historical reef disturbances, the paleobiological markers show diverse fish assemblages often established themselves in degraded reef environments before coral recovery had progressed beyond minimal levels. In some cases, fish communities reached peak diversity when coral cover remained below 15%—far lower than current consensus models would predict as viable. Dr. Pichomen has argued that this suggests prevailing theories about reef recovery have the dependency relationship reversed: rather than coral complexity enabling fish communities, it may be that certain fish behaviors actively facilitate coral larval settlement and polyp survival, meaning fish-first colonization could accelerate rather than follow from coral recovery. But Dr. Koralla, in his most recent paper, makes a compelling empirical case that neither the consensus model nor Dr. Pichomen's newer theory can adequately explain the apparent change in sequencing, and proposes further research into whether differences in ocean salinity may explain the results. In recent years, rising global temperatures have led to increased evaporation in many shallow tropical waters historically hospital to coral reefs (effectively concentrating the existing salt), and decreasing in other historic reef zones in which increased freshwater runoff from nearby landmasses is diluting salinity.	**Question 3.4: Paragraph Purpose** Which of the following best describes the function of the second paragraph in the passage? **A.** It outlines several interpretations of evidence that complicates an expectation established in the first paragraph. **B.** It offers an alternative explanation for observations described in the first paragraph. **C.** It questions the validity of the fundamental assumptions underlying the research outlined in the first paragraph. **D.** It broadens the temporal scope of the findings discussed in the first paragraph. **E.** It attempts to reconcile several conflicting theories derived from new research methodologies.

	Difficulty: 4/5 **A. CORRECT
Coral Reefs occupy just 1% of the seafloor but support over 25% of all marine life, contribute to the livelihood of over 1 billion humans, and offer vital protection from storm surges that increasingly threaten many coastal regions. But many of our remaining reefs are periodically decimated during even relatively brief periods in which seawater temperatures rise beyond that in which the delicate reef ecosystems are possible. When marine ecologists set out to understand coral reef recovery following thermal bleaching events, they tracked two observable phenomena: the return of coral polyp colonies and the reappearance of reef fish populations. Current consensus models emphasize that reef structural complexity—created by coral growth—is the necessary precondition for fish communities to recolonize areas Biologists, such as Dr. Pichomen and Dr. Koralla, have traditionally studied reefs by monitoring reef sites across the Indo-Pacific following major bleaching episodes, documenting coral regrowth rates and fish population dynamics. Field observations at several recently bleached sites	**Question 3.5: ATTP** According to the passage, which of the following is potentially indicated by paleobiological markers? **A.** The rate at which coral polyps regenerate following thermal stress

initially seemed to confirm expectations: coral colonies regrew slowly, and fish populations returned only after sufficient coral cover had been reestablished. Recently, a new technique pioneered by Professor Glossamin is focused on analyzing sediment core samples that preserve chemical signatures of historical biodiversity, which she calls paleobiological markers. In the periods following many historical reef disturbances, the paleobiological markers show diverse fish assemblages often established themselves in degraded reef environments before coral recovery had progressed beyond minimal levels. In some cases, fish communities reached peak diversity when coral cover remained below 15%—far lower than current consensus models would predict as viable. Dr. Pichomen has argued that this suggests prevailing theories about reef recovery have the dependency relationship reversed: rather than coral complexity enabling fish communities, it may be that certain fish behaviors actively facilitate coral larval settlement and polyp survival, meaning fish-first colonization could accelerate rather than follow from coral recovery. But Dr. Koralla, in his most recent paper, makes a compelling empirical case that neither the consensus model nor Dr. Pichomen's newer theory can adequately explain the apparent change in sequencing, and proposes further research into whether differences in ocean salinity may explain the results. In recent years, rising global temperatures have led to increased evaporation in many shallow tropical waters historically hospital to coral reefs (effectively concentrating the existing salt), and decreasing in other historic reef zones in which increased freshwater runoff from nearby landmasses is diluting salinity.	**B.** The paleochemical composition of reef polyps and larval settlements in multiple stages of recovery **C.** The historical timing of fish community establishment relative to coral recovery **D.** The mechanisms by which fish behaviors facilitate coral larval settlement **E.** The percentage of coral cover necessary to support minimal fish populations

	Difficulty: 3/5 C
READING COMPREHENSION — SHORT PASSAGE B **Questions 17–18 are based upon the following passage.** For much of the twentieth century, literary canons were often treated as relatively stable collections of works believed to possess enduring aesthetic value. Some recent scholars, however, have argued that such canons are shaped as much by institutional priorities—such as curricular constraints and publishing practices—as by purely literary merit. While this perspective helps explain why certain voices were historically marginalized, it remains controversial, particularly among other scholars who maintain that individual judgment and sustained reader engagement, rather than institutional influence, are the primary determinants of a work's lasting significance.	**Question 17** The passage is primarily concerned with: (A) defending traditional literary canons against recent criticism (B) describing an ongoing debate about how literary canons form and evolve (C) explaining how institutional pressures have replaced aesthetic standards (D) arguing that literary merit cannot be defined objectively (E) outlining the criteria by which universities select course materials

	— Difficulty: 3/5 **Correct Answer:** (B) **Explanation:** The passage presents two competing perspectives on canon formation and emphasizes that the issue remains unsettled. (C) is the most tempting distractor because institutional influence is discussed, but the passage does not claim that such pressures have *replaced* aesthetic standards—only that some critics believe they play a major role.
Questions 17–18 are based upon the following passage. For much of the twentieth century, literary canons were often treated as relatively stable collections of works believed to possess enduring aesthetic value. Some recent scholars, however, have argued that such canons are shaped as much by institutional priorities—such as curricular constraints and publishing practices—as by purely literary merit. While this perspective helps explain why certain voices were historically marginalized, it remains controversial, particularly among other scholars who maintain that individual judgment and sustained reader engagement, rather than institutional influence, are the primary determinants of a work's lasting significance.	**Question 18** Which of the following is most likely to be a point of disagreement about literary canons between the two groups of scholars described in the passage? (A) Whether their enduring aesthetic value can ever be assessed purely upon literary merit (B) Whether institutional forces influence which works become widely taught in them (C) Whether readers should engage critically with literary texts in them rather than accept those texts on the basis of their merit (D) Whether the options and actions of individual readers are more or less of a factor in shaping them than are decisions and policies of large organizations (E) Whether the study of literature should include contemporary works that has yet to be proven or whether it should focus on those works that have already

	established their enduring aesthetic value **— Difficulty: 3/5** **Correct Answer:** (D)
Questions 19–22 are based on this passage For decades, the standard historical narrative has posited that the advent of agriculture represented a deterministic threshold in human social evolution and the end of the default egalitarian organization of foraging societies. In this framework, the cultivation of crops inextricably led to the accumulation of surplus, the invention of rigid social hierarchies, and the birth of the modern state. However, in their recently published *The Dawn of Everything*, anthropologists David Graeber and David Wengrow challenge this linear technological determinism. By examining the archaeological and historical records of early indigenous peoples, they reveal that many early societies actually engaged in conscious, fluid political experimentation. Numerous indigenous groups, for instance, seasonally alternated between authoritarian structures during specific harvest or hunting periods and egalitarian assemblies during others. Graeber and Wengrow argue that this periodic fluidity suggests early humans possessed a high degree of political self-consciousness, deliberately organizing and dismantling hierarchies as required, and thus the eventual entrenchment of permanent social	

inequality was not the inevitable byproduct of agricultural surplus, but rather the result of a subsequent loss of this earlier political flexibility.

19. The primary purpose of the passage is to

(A) trace the chronological progression of political hierarchy from its origins in foraging to its entrenchment in the modern state

(B) challenge an unwarranted assumption that the historical narrative often makes regarding modern states as fundamentally less hierarchical than the authoritarian structures that emerged with the dawn of agriculture

(C) outline a recently published anthropological framework that disputes a strictly sequential model of early human social organization

(D) reconcile the traditional narrative of the agricultural revolution with new evidence of conscious political experimentation

(E) explain some of the methods used by anthropologists to determine the social structures of pre-agricultural societies

20. In the context of the passage as a whole, the author most likely mentions that numerous groups "seasonally alternated" in order to

(A) introduce a phenomenon that serves as one example of the inevitable social inequalities created by the accumulation of surplus

(B) provide support for the theory that agricultural cultivation required strict authoritarian oversight

(C) correct a common misconception regarding the degree to which human activities dictate political structures rather than vice versa

(D) illustrate a degree of political flexibility that undermines the assumption of a rigid, unidirectional social evolution

(E) identify the specific environmental conditions that forced early human populations to abandon foraging in favor of agriculture

21. Which of the following can be most reliably inferred from the passage regarding the "standard historical narrative"?

(A) It evaluates the success of early human societies primarily through the lens of their ability to dismantle authoritarian structures.

(B) It correctly identifies agricultural surplus as the cause of seasonal fluidity in early indigenous populations.

(C) It relies on archaeological evidence that Graeber and Wengrow have definitively proven to be fabricated.

(D) It treats the egalitarianism of early foraging societies as a passive state dictated by subsistence rather than as a conscious political choice.

(E) It is predicated on the belief that egalitarianism may form temporarily in early human societies, but will be dismantled once agricultural surpluses are exhausted.

22. According to the passage, Graeber and Wengrow assert that the entrenchment of permanent social inequality was

(A) a structural byproduct of the specific environmental pressures that necessitated crop cultivation

(B) directly proportional to the amount of agricultural surplus generated by a specific foraging group

(C) the result of indigenous groups organizing hierarchical structures that they were subsequently unable to dismantle

(D) the inevitable outcome of humans abandoning fluid political experimentation in favor of technological determinism

(E) the consequence of a decline in the conscious political experimentation previously exhibited by human societies

(this is meant for section 1)

Explanations:

19. (C) Correct.

- (A) **Ø What.** The passage critiques this linear tracing; it does not perform it.
- (B) **Ø What.** The passage does not claim the traditional narrative views modern states as *less* hierarchical.
- **(C) Correct.** Summarizes the structural pivot: introducing a recent anthropological work that disputes the traditional deterministic/sequential model of human history.
- (D) **False Pivot.** The passage introduces a framework that *challenges* the traditional narrative, rather than *reconciling* with it.
- (E) **Ø What.** Methods are mentioned ("archaeological and historical records"), but they are not the primary focus of the explanation.

20. (D) Correct.

- (A) **Direct Contradiction.** It is an example of *flexibility*, not the "inevitable inequalities" of surplus.
- (B) **False Pivot.** The text argues *against* this strict necessity.

- (C) **Causal Inversion.** It corrects the misconception that structures dictate activities, arguing instead that human agency (activities) deliberately shapes structures.
- **(D) Correct.** The detail of seasonal alternation is utilized structurally to illustrate the political flexibility that disproves the assumption of "rigid, unidirectional" social evolution.
- (E) **Ø What.** Environmental conditions forcing an abandonment of foraging are not discussed.

21. (D) Correct.

- (A) **Ø What.** The standard narrative's criteria for "success" is not discussed.
- (B) **Direct Contradiction.** The narrative does not identify surplus as a cause of *fluidity*; it identifies it as the end of it.
- (C) **Word-Salad Trap.** The authors re-examine the records; they do not claim the evidence itself was fabricated.
- **(D) Correct.** By framing egalitarianism as a "default" and hierarchy as an "inextricable" invention of agriculture, the standard narrative logically assumes (takes for granted) that early humans lacked the agency to consciously choose their structures independent of their subsistence method.
- (E) **Direct Contradiction.** The narrative assumes egalitarianism is the *default*, permanent state until agriculture, not a temporary formation.

22. (E) Correct.

- (A) **Direct Contradiction.** This is the view of the standard historical narrative, not Graeber and Wengrow.
- (B) **Ø What.** Proportionality is never quantified.
- (C) **Ø When.** The text says they organized and *dismantled* structures, not that they were "subsequently unable" to dismantle them.
- (D) **ARM Trap.** They didn't abandon experimentation *in favor of* technological determinism; the *historians* use technological determinism to describe the shift.
- **(E) Correct.** The final sentence explicitly asserts that permanent inequality was the consequence of a "subsequent loss of this earlier political flexibility" (i.e., a decline in conscious experimentation).

Questions 23–25 are based on this passage

In the mid-twentieth century, the paradigm of American urban planning was heavily influenced by Robert Moses, who championed a top-down, automobile-centric vision of city building. Operating on the premise that a city's vitality depended on the efficient movement of vehicular traffic and the strict segregation of distinct functional zones, Moses utilized unprecedented civic authority to enact vast expressway networks and large-scale "slum clearance." This centralized, macro-level approach was fiercely contested, most notably by Jane Jacobs, who proposed a radically diffuse model for a healthy urban ecosystem. Jacobs argued that advocates for Moses's infrastructural "improvements" failed to see the value in what they destroyed or the hidden costs of what they created. She outlined the means by which diversity—of business and residential, of ages and styles of buildings, of income, of street size and length, and even of usages through times of day and days of the week—was not mere inefficiency, but actually offered enormous benefits, in the form of "eyes on the street" and incidental interactions that create safety, community, and vibrance, and that could never be replicated with more

regimented and segregated uses. In her view, the massive infrastructural investments in public housing, highways, and even parks often were doomed to fail because they lacked these assets. Furthermore, she identified numerous other negative consequences that highways could have on the neighborhoods that they purported to serve, and the degree to which the alleged drawbacks that critics claimed would invariably result from her proposals for reductions in the accommodations for automobiles in urban areas generally failed to materialize.

23. The primary purpose of the passage is to

(A) reconcile the infrastructural improvements championed by Robert Moses with the diverse urban ecosystems proposed by Jane Jacobs

(B) outline a historical conflict between important proponents of centralized versus decentralized models for city vitality

(C) demonstrate that the alleged drawbacks of decentralized urban planning generally failed to materialize

(D) evaluate the hidden costs associated with the failure of massive public housing projects in the mid-twentieth century

(E) argue that reductions in automobile accommodations invariably produce the community vibrance necessary for urban resilience

24. Which of the following can be most reliably inferred from the passage regarding Robert Moses's approach to urban planning?

(A) It viewed the incidental interactions of a neighborhood as a secondary but necessary component of traffic efficiency.

(B) It recognized the value of diffuse urban ecosystems but prioritized the construction of expressway networks as a temporary measure.

(C) It relied on the continuous vigilance of local residents to formalize top-down policing efforts.

(D) It evaluated the success of a city environment using metrics that inherently undervalued the localized social dynamics of mixed-use areas.

(E) It was somewhat more likely to prioritize the preservation of existing residential spaces than was the approach advocated by Jane Jacobs.

25. As used in the passage, the word "purported" most nearly means

(A) "were designed" (systematically)

(B) "were imported" (from outside expertise)

(C) "intended" (but failed to)

(D) "claimed" (often falsely, by advocates)

(E) "were mandated" (by civic authority)

(this is meant for section 1)

23. (B) Correct.

- (A) **False Pivot.** The passage contrasts these two figures; it makes no attempt to reconcile them.
- **(B) Correct.** The passage is structurally organized around a binary conflict, contrasting Moses's top-down, centralized approach with Jacobs's organic, decentralized approach.
- (C) **Too Narrow.** This addresses only the final clause of the passage.
- (D) **Too Narrow.** The failure of public housing is a supporting detail used to validate Jacobs's broader critique, not the primary focus of the entire passage.
- (E) **Extreme Language.** The passage states that Jacobs outlined how diversity offered benefits, but it does not claim that reducing automobile accommodations *invariably* (always, without exception) produces vibrance.

24. (D) Correct.

- (A) **Direct Contradiction / ARM Trap.** He didn't view pedestrian interaction as "secondary but necessary"; Jacobs argued his policies destroyed those interactions entirely in favor of traffic efficiency.
- (B) **Ø When.** There is no evidence in the text that Moses viewed expressways as a "temporary measure" or that he ever recognized the value of diffuse ecosystems.
- (C) **Direct Contradiction.** Jacobs championed local vigilance ("eyes on the street"), whereas Moses utilized "unprecedented civic authority" and top-down interventions.
- **(D) Correct.** If Moses championed the "strict segregation of distinct functional zones" and operated on the premise that vitality depended on "efficient movement of vehicular traffic," we can reliably infer that his metrics for success inherently ignored or undervalued the localized, mixed-use dynamics (the "incidental interactions" and diversity) that Jacobs identified as actual assets.
- (E) **Direct Contradiction.** Moses championed large-scale "slum clearance," which inherently destroys existing residential spaces.

25. (D) Correct.

- (A) **False Synonym.** While the highways may have been systematically designed, "purported" specifically targets the rhetorical *claim* made by the advocates, emphasizing the gap between promise and reality.
- (B) **False Synonym.** "Purported" does not relate to importation.
- (C) **Near Miss.** While intention is implied, "purported" strictly refers to what is stated, professed, or claimed outwardly, rather than the internal intent.

- **(D) Correct.** In the context of highways negatively impacting the neighborhoods they "purported to serve," the word indicates that advocates *claimed* the highways would serve the neighborhoods, but the reality (the "negative consequences") did not match the claim.
- (E) **False Synonym.** "Purported" does not mean mandated or required.

Questions 26–28 are based on this passage

The botanical trajectory of the cultivated apple in North America underscores a stark transition from an initial surplus of genetic variance to a modern biological deficit. Early colonial orchards, grown primarily from imported seed, were characterized by extreme genetic heterozygosity. While this rampant genetic variance produced astringent fruit suited only for hard cider, it simultaneously fostered highly resilient, locally adapted tree populations. The nineteenth-century shift toward grafting—the cloning of desirable fruit-bearing branches onto established rootstocks —transformed the apple into a palatable commodity and precipitated a golden age of American pomology, generating thousands of distinct cultivars. However, by universally adopting clonal propagation, the agricultural industry effectively halted the apple's natural evolutionary adaptation. As twentieth-century commercial supply chains increasingly demanded visually uniform, transportable varieties, the industry came to rely upon a scant fraction of these genetic lines—lines that could no longer adapt independently to new pests or changing climates. Consequently, modern commercial orchards require massive chemical interventions to maintain the viability of clones frozen in time over a century ago, yielding fruit that prioritizes structural durability at the steep expense of the complex flavor profiles that characterized earlier cultivars.

26. The primary purpose of the passage is to

(A) describe the underlying biological mechanisms that dictate the phenotypic traits of a specific plant species (B) challenge a widely held assumption about the inherent ecological resilience of early agricultural practices (C) trace the historical development of a cultivated crop to highlight the unintended consequences of its commercial standardization (D) reconcile competing historical interpretations regarding the dietary utility of a particular frontier resource (E) contrast two fundamentally distinct historical methodologies for cultivating a particular agricultural product

27. According to the passage, the widespread adoption of clonal propagation in the nineteenth century resulted in

(A) an unprecedented expansion of distinct, edible apple varieties prior to a period of commercial contraction (B) the spontaneous generation of locally adapted tree populations capable of withstanding emerging climatic shifts (C) a renewed reliance on imported European seeds to maintain the extreme genetic heterozygosity of frontier orchards (D) the immediate necessity for massive chemical interventions to preserve astringent hard cider cultivars (E) the immediate standardization of the apple into a few visually uniform,

transportable varieties

28. The passage implies which of the following about apple trees grown directly from seed?

(A) They produce fruit that is devoid of agricultural utility. (B) Their extreme genetic variance rendered them incapable of surviving outside their native European habitats. (C) They yield fruit that is generally superior for pressing into hard cider than fruit from twentieth-century commercial varieties. (D) They are more susceptible to environmental pests and climatic shifts than are modern commercial clones. (E) Their phenotypic development is highly unlikely to mirror the specific traits of their parentage.

Questions 26–28: Apple Cultivation 26. (C) Correct.

- (A) **Too Narrow / Ø What.** The passage briefly defines heterozygosity, but it does not primarily aim to *describe the biological mechanisms* behind it; this is just a supporting detail in the first paragraph.
- (B) **Direct Contradiction.** The passage actually *supports* the idea that early practices (seed-grown orchards) were ecologically resilient; it does not challenge that assumption.
- **(C) Correct.** This captures the abstract rhetorical structure of the text: it traces the "historical development" of the apple (from seed-grown, to grafted, to commercialized) to highlight the "unintended consequences" (the biological deficit and loss of ecological resilience) of standardizing it.
- (D) **False Pivot.** There are no "competing historical interpretations" mentioned in the text that need to be reconciled.
- (E) **Too Narrow.** While the passage does mention grafting versus seed propagation, *contrasting* these methodologies is merely a stepping stone to the passage's broader conclusion about modern commercial vulnerability.

27. (A) Correct.

- **(A) Correct.** The passage explicitly states grafting "precipitated a golden age of American pomology, generating thousands of distinct cultivars" before twentieth-century markets narrowed the focus.
- (B) **Direct Contradiction.** Seed propagation (heterozygosity) caused the locally adapted populations; clonal propagation halted this natural evolutionary adaptation.
- (C) **Word-Salad Trap.** Misuses terms from the opening paragraph in the wrong chronological context.
- (D) **Chronological Trap.** Chemical interventions are a modern (contemporary) necessity, not an immediate result in the nineteenth century.
- (E) **Chronological Trap.** The narrowing into visually uniform varieties happened as a result of *twentieth-century* commercial supply chains.

28. (E) Correct.

- (A) **Direct Contradiction.** The fruit was astringent and used for hard cider, proving it possessed agricultural utility.
- (B) **Direct Contradiction.** The passage explicitly states they fostered "highly resilient, locally adapted tree populations," meaning they were highly capable of surviving.
- (C) **Out of Scope.** The passage never compares the cider-pressing quality of seed-grown apples to twentieth-century commercial varieties.

- (D) **Direct Contradiction.** The passage states that the modern commercial clones "could no longer adapt to new pests," whereas the seed-grown populations were "highly resilient."
- **(E) Correct.** The passage explicitly states that because of extreme genetic heterozygosity, trees propagated from seed "rarely exhibit the phenotypic traits of their parentage."

Questions 29–32 are based on this passage

For decades, architectural historiography struggled to classify Julia Morgan. Because her most famous commission, Hearst Castle, relied heavily on the stylistic pastiche of the Beaux-Arts tradition, mid-century critics often dismissed her as a mere traditionalist operating outside the boundaries of modernism. However, recent scholarship has reevaluated Morgan's legacy by focusing on her early and vociferous adoption of reinforced concrete. At a time when unreinforced masonry and timber constituted the unquestioned orthopraxy for institutional design, she recognized the fatal limitations of these traditional materials in seismically volatile California, adopting a novel composite that integrated steel tensile matrices within a concrete medium. Her 1904 El Campanil bell tower at Mills College utilized this technique to profound effect. When the catastrophic 1906 San Francisco earthquake decimated the surrounding regional infrastructure, Morgan's tower emerged structurally unscathed. By concealing cutting-edge, earthquake-resistant steel and concrete frameworks beneath historicist facades, Morgan deliberately separated the visual language of a building from its structural reality. Thus, rather than ignoring the industrial advances of modernism, she stealthily appropriated them to support the physical survival of traditional architectural forms.

29. The primary purpose of the passage is to

(A) provide a comprehensive comparison between the architectural styles of Hearst Castle and the tenets of mid-century modernism (B) reevaluate an architect's historical legacy by emphasizing the structural ingenuity underlying her aesthetic traditionalism (C) argue that aesthetic considerations were entirely secondary to structural integrity in early twentieth-century Californian architecture (D) outline the specific chronological progression of California's building codes following the integration of reinforced concrete (E) reconcile the stylistic eclecticism of Beaux-Arts architecture with the rigid visual language of industrial modernism

30. In the context of the passage as a whole, the author mentions that Morgan "deliberately separated the visual language of a building from its structural reality" in order to

(A) provide an explanation for why mid-century architectural critics initially miscategorized her professional methodologies (B) evaluate the hidden aesthetic costs associated with prioritizing seismic safety in urban design (C) identify the specific environmental pressures that necessitated the invention of the Beaux-Arts tradition (D) document the precise historical moment when wooden architecture was definitively abandoned in California (E) correct a common misconception regarding the extent of the damage suffered by unreinforced masonry in California

31. The passage suggests that recent scholarship regarding Julia Morgan (Select all that apply)

▢ rejects the premise that her architectural practice was entirely isolated from the industrial advances of modernism. ▢ heavily critiques the structural integrity of her most famous commission, Hearst Castle. ▢ focuses on the tension between her use of classical facades and her application of progressive building materials.

32. As used in the passage, the word "appropriated" most nearly means

(A) evaluated through the lens of mid-century aesthetic criticism (B) authorized a specific amount of funds for a project (C) judged to be proper or fitting for a particular circumstance (D) harnessed and adapted for a specific, often diverging, utility (E) systematically dismantled into constituent parts

Questions 29–32: Julia Morgan 29. (B) Correct.

- (A) **False Pivot.** It mentions both, but does not provide a "comprehensive comparison" of their tenets.
- **(B) Correct.** Captures the structural goal: the text challenges her classification as a mere traditionalist by reevaluating her legacy in light of her progressive structural engineering methodologies.
- (C) **Extreme Language.** The passage does not claim aesthetics were "entirely secondary"; she sought to achieve her aesthetic visions without compromising integrity.
- (D) **Ø What.** Building codes are not mentioned.
- (E) **Word-Salad Trap.** Uses passage terms incorrectly.

30. (A) Correct.

- **(A) Correct.** Because her visual language (traditionalism) obscured her structural reality (modernism), critics who only looked at the surface incorrectly dismissed her as "a mere traditionalist."
- (B) **Ø What.** "Hidden aesthetic costs" are never discussed.
- (C) **Ø What.** The environmental pressures (earthquakes) necessitated reinforced concrete, not the Beaux-Arts tradition.
- (D) **Ø What.** Wooden architecture is never discussed.
- (E) **Ø What.** The passage doesn't address "misconceptions" about the damage to masonry, but rather Morgan's response to its known fatal limitations.

31. (Boxes 1 and 3 only) Correct.

- **(Box 1) Correct.** Recent scholarship highlights her use of cutting-edge steel and concrete frameworks, rejecting the idea she operated "outside the boundaries of modernism."
- (Box 2) **Direct Contradiction.** Scholarship does not critique the structural integrity; it reveals that she secretly utilized incredibly strong, earthquake-resistant engineering.
- **(Box 3) Correct.** Supported by the detail that she deliberately separated the visual language of

a building from its structural reality.

32. (D) Correct.

- (A) **Word-Salad Trap.** Pulls concepts from earlier in the text.
- (B) **False Synonym.** (Financial definition).
- (C) **False Synonym.**
- **(D) Correct.** In the context of her taking industrial modern advances and using them to "support the physical survival of traditional architectural forms," it means she harnessed and adapted them for her own specific utility.
- (E) **False Synonym.**

Question 33 is based on this passage

Questions 34–36 are based on this passage

The assimilation of pizza into the mainstream American diet following World War II represents more than a mere shift in consumer demographics; it illustrates the mechanisms by which industrial food processing fundamentally alters the ontological status of cultural artifacts. Initially confined to Southern Italian immigrant enclaves, traditional pizza was defined by its localized constraints: it required specialized high-heat masonry ovens and immediate consumption. When returning soldiers generated a national demand for the dish in the 1950s, the commercial food industry sought to capitalize on this popularity. However, to distribute the food nationally to consumers lacking specialized equipment, manufacturers had to re-engineer the product for the home freezer. This necessitated replacing artisanal doughs and fresh cheeses with stabilized, freeze-tolerant alternatives. Consequently, the commercialization of pizza did not simply expand the reach of an ethnic dish; it eradicated the dish's defining artisanal characteristics, replacing a localized cultural practice with a standardized, industrial facsimile.

34. The author most likely mentions "returning soldiers" in order to

(A) contrast the culinary preferences of mid-century soldiers with those of late-nineteenth-century Italian immigrants (B) evaluate the economic impact of the postwar boom on the artisanal restaurant industries of New York and Chicago (C) identify the specific demographic catalyst that expanded a food's consumer base beyond its original ethnic enclave (D) argue that the mass production of frozen foods was a direct consequence of postwar industrial capacity (E) reconcile the artisanal roots of a specific dish with its modern status as a convenience food

35. The passage suggests which of the following about the "national demand" for pizza generated by returning soldiers?

(A) It inevitably led to the decline of traditional artisanal bakeries operating within urban ethnic enclaves. (B) It necessitated an industrial departure from the localized preparation constraints that initially defined the dish. (C) It was uniformly embraced by the broader American public as an alternative to domestic convenience foods. (D) It could only be satisfied by importing massive quantities of commercial freezing technologies directly from Southern Italy. (E) It completely eradicated the cultural and historical significance of the dish among its original immigrant demographic.

36. The passage mentions which of the following occurring as part of the commercialization of pizza in the 1950s?

(A) An organized effort by the commercial food industry to actively discourage the perpetuation of Southern Italian cultural practices. (B) A temporary reduction in the cost of raw ingredients required to prepare the dish in high-end urban restaurants. (C) A technological adaptation that allowed artisanal doughs and fresh cheeses to be perfectly preserved during national distribution. (D) The deliberate substitution of historically localized ingredients with standardized industrial alternatives. (E) The restriction of a food's availability to consumer demographics that possessed specific high-heat masonry equipment.

Questions 34–36: Pizza History 34. (C) Correct.

- (A) **False Pivot.** It describes an expansion of a consumer base, not a contrast of preferences.
- (B) **Ø What.** The economic impact on artisanal restaurants is not the focus.
- **(C) Correct.** The returning soldiers with a taste for it provided the specific demographic demand that pulled the food out of its ethnic enclaves.
- (D) **Word-Salad Trap.** Mixes terms from different parts of the passage.
- (E) **False Pivot.** It describes how the roots were eradicated, not reconciled.

35. (B) Correct.

- (A) **Out of Scope.** The passage discusses the commercialization of pizza for a national market, but it never mentions the subsequent economic impact on the original artisanal bakeries within those ethnic enclaves.
- **(B) Correct.** The passage explicitly states that to distribute the food nationally to consumers "lacking specialized equipment," the industry had to "re-engineer the product" and replace artisanal doughs with freeze-tolerant alternatives. This directly implies an industrial departure from the localized methods (masonry ovens and immediate consumption).
- (C) **Too Strong.** While the passage notes it became a mainstream staple, claiming it was *uniformly* embraced (by everyone, without exception) sets a definitive bar not cleared by the text.
- (D) **Out of Scope / Source Trap.** The text mentions the advent of commercial freezing technologies in the 1950s, but there is no evidence to suggest this technology was imported from Southern Italy.

● (E) **Too Strong.** The commercialization process eradicated the dish's defining artisanal characteristics in the *frozen product*, but claiming this demand "completely eradicated" the cultural and historical significance among the *original immigrant demographic* is a massive, unsupported leap. **36. (D) Correct.** ● (A) **Motive Trap.** The industry sought to "capitalize on this popularity" to make money; the text does not state they had an organized agenda to "actively discourage" the culture. ● (B) **Ø What.** The cost of raw ingredients in high-end restaurants is not discussed. ● (C) **Direct Contradiction.** The text states this required "replacing artisanal doughs and fresh cheeses with stabilized, freeze-tolerant alternatives." ● **(D) Correct.** The passage explicitly states that manufacturers had to "standardize the recipe" by replacing artisanal ingredients with "stabilized, freeze-tolerant alternatives." ● (E) **Direct Contradiction.** It expanded availability to "consumers lacking specialized equipment."	

Tier 1: Linear & Definitional (Easiest)

- **1.** Q21 ("In searching for norms..."): 1BTC. Direct definitional mapping of "ought to be."

- **2.** Q17 ("Everyone has routines..."): 2BTC. Direct synonym mapping ("routines" = "habit").
- **3.** Q4 ("Serling's account..."): 2BTC. Simple contrast ("wary" vs "reckless").
- **4.** Q8 ("Vladimir Nabokov..."): 2BTC. Simple syntax, though it contains an anti-real-world trap.

Tier 2: Single Pivots & False Pairs

- **5.** Q22 ("chimpanzees feigning..."): 1BTC. Advanced vocab ("dissemble") mapped to a simple clue.
- **6.** Q1 ("presumed not to exist..."): 1BTC. Requires navigating a double-negative.
- **7.** Q9 ("Unenlightened authoritarian..."): 1BTC. Relies on a Degree Trap ("schism").
- **8.** Q23 ("Instant celebrity..."): 2BTC. Exemplification trap.
- **9.** Q7 ("Overlarge, uneven..."): SE. Punishes matching without reading (False Pair trap).
- **10.** Q28 ("Parkin's characterization..."): SE. False Flag trap.
- **11.** Q20 ("kind of movie... conventionally"): SE. Double negation pivot.

Tier 3: Multi-Clause Logic & Parallelism

- **12.** Q6 ("The government's implementation..."): SE. High-level False Pair trap (placid/tranquil).
- **13.** Q12 ("Though feminist in its..."): SE. Chronological pivot.
- **14.** Q2 ("Human nature and long..."): 2BTC. Causal pivot based on real-world logic.
- **15.** Q25 ("The gaps in existing accounts..."): 2BTC. Strict cause-and-effect ("since").
- **16.** Q24 ("At their best..."): 2BTC. Tone constraint balancing.
- **17.** Q15 ("The incipient (i)..."): 2BTC. Clue delay + arcane vocabulary ("row").
- **18.** Q26 ("That today's students..."): 3BTC. Temporal pivot across multiple blanks.
- **19.** Q19 ("Massachusetts Bay Colony..."): 3BTC. Strict parallelism trap demanding 1:1 binary opposites.

Tier 4: Irony, Displaced Targets & Multi-Constraints

- **20.** Q10 ("Belanger dances with an..."): 2BTC. Threading the needle (paradox of drawing attention while detached).
- **21.** Q16 ("Unlike the problems..."): 2BTC. Displaced target (unpremeditated perfectly fits the *other* side of the pivot).

- **22.** Q5 ("Philosophy... does not try..."): 3BTC. Pure paradox (the familiar becomes mysterious).
- **23.** Q11 ("The most striking thing..."): 3BTC. Displaced target balancing self-interest and higher purpose.
- **24.** Q14 ("Only with the discovery..."): 3BTC. Multi-pivot logic ("although").
- **25.** Q18 ("Repression of painful..."): 3BTC. Reverse-engineering clues + tight syntactical constraints.

Tier 5: The "Anti-Linear" Masterpieces (Hardest)

- **26.** Q13 ("Wills argues that certain..."): 3BTC. Extreme clue delay. You cannot answer Blank (i) until you read the final word of the paragraph.
- **27.** Q27 ("The serious study of pop culture..."): 3BTC. Extreme threading the needle. Forces the reader to map out psychological hypocrisy across all three blanks simultaneously.
- **28.** Q3 ("No other contemporary poet's..."): 3BTC. The ultimate trap collection. Contains a brutal Displaced Target (the right word for the *past* timeline is a distractor for the *present* timeline) and a False Flag placed at the very end to intentionally break the reader's structural assumptions.